

To determine the type of leadership that most promotes organisational commitment

Supervisor:

Assoc. Prof. Richard Pospisil, Ph.D.

Thomas Meixner

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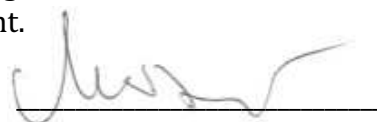
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Abstract

The present work is concerned with the topic of organizational commitment and the question, how this highly relevant construct can be fostered by leaders and managers in corporate settings. The contemporary business environment is shaped by a strong focus on employees, their skills, knowledge and subsequently motivation, to achieve favorable goals for their respective companies. With regard to the war for talent this thesis showcases, how a focus on attracting and subsequently retaining highly qualified and highly motivated employees can be a feasible strategy for businesses in different fields.

Organizational commitment is herein described as a complex construct consisting of various facets that are in relationships with each other. Especially the role of behavioral and emotional commitment are highlighted as predictive valid for various organizational outcomes. The leading research question of this thesis therefore is, how organizational commitment can in a first step be operationalized and measured and in a second step fostered by leaders.

Following an extensive literature review on the concepts of leadership, organizational commitment and personality and values as moderating factors between the two first mentioned constructs, this thesis followed an empirical approach to address the research question presented therein. A total of three publications was developed in order to foster understanding of the complex relationship between leadership and organizational commitment. These three publications employ the perspective of employees from different industries and are based on a cumulative sample of more than $n = 900$ employees, spread between the three individual studies.

In a first step, the factor structure of a newly developed measure for organizational commitment was assessed and validated. Based on pre-existing items and a complex analysis strategy following the framework of a confirmative factor analysis, the two-factor structure of organizational commitment as a construct consisting of emotional and behavioral aspects could be established.

The subsequent publications utilized this newly developed measure in order to assess the predictive power of leadership variables and personality traits. Therein it could be shown, that while personality traits and personal values do take on a

moderating role, it is ultimately (transformational) leadership that has the strongest predictive power in regard to organizational commitment. This, subsequently is also the main contribution of the present work, which is described throughout this thesis both in regard to potential limitations and to the contribution concerning the current state of research.

Keywords

Organizational Commitment; Leadership; Personality; Personal Values

Abstrakt

Tato práce se zabývá tématem organizačního závazku a otázkou, jak mohou vedoucí pracovníci a manažeři v podnikovém prostředí tento velmi důležitý konstrukt podporovat. Současné podnikatelské prostředí je utvářeno silným důrazem na zaměstnance, jejich schopnosti, znalosti a následně motivaci, aby dosáhli příznivých cílů pro příslušné firmy. S ohledem na válku o talenty tato práce ukazuje, jak může být zaměření na získávání a následné udržení vysoce kvalifikovaných a vysoce motivovaných zaměstnanců realizovatelnou strategií pro podniky v různých oblastech.

Organizační závazek je zde popsán jako komplexní konstrukt sestávající z různých aspektů, které jsou ve vzájemných vztazích. Zejména role behaviorálního a emocionálního závazku jsou zdůrazněny jako prediktivní faktory platné pro různé organizační výsledky. Hlavní výzkumnou otázkou této práce proto je, jak může být organizační závazek v prvním kroku operacionalizován a měřen a v druhém kroku podporován vedoucími pracovníky.

Po rozsáhlém přehledu literatury o koncepcích vedení, organizačního závazku a osobnosti a hodnot jako moderujících faktorů mezi prvními dvěma zmíněnými konstrukty se tato práce řídila empirickým přístupem k řešení výzkumné otázky v

ní uvedené. Byly vypracovány celkem tři publikace s cílem podpořit pochopení komplexního vztahu mezi vedením a organizačním závazkem. Tyto tři publikace využívají pohled zaměstnanců z různých průmyslových odvětví a jsou založeny na souhrnném vzorku více než $n = 900$ zaměstnanců, který je rozdělen mezi tři jednotlivé studie.

V prvním kroku byla posouzena a ověřena faktorová struktura nově vyvinutého měřítko organizačního závazku. Na základě již existujících položek a komplexní strategie analýzy podle rámce konfirmační faktorové analýzy bylo možné stanovit dvoufaktorovou strukturu organizačního závazku jako konstrukt sestávajícího z emocionálních a behaviorálních aspektů.

V následujících publikacích byla tato nově vyvinutá míra využita k posouzení prediktivní síly proměnných vedení a osobnostních rysů. Na základě toho se ukázalo, že ačkoli osobnostní rysy a osobní hodnoty hrají moderující roli, je to nakonec (transformační) vedení, které má nejsilnější prediktivní sílu, pokud jde o organizační závazek. To je následně také hlavním přínosem této práce, který je popsán v celé práci jak s ohledem na možná omezení, tak na kontribuci týkající se současného stavu výzkumu.

Klíčová slova

Organizační závazek; Vedení; Osobnost; Osobní hodnoty

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1 Introduction

„Leadership is as old as mankind. It is universal, and inescapable. It exists everywhere. (...) For leadership to exist, of course, there has to be a group: but wherever a group exists, there is always a form of leadership.“ (Blondel, 1987, p. 1) Leadership as a construct seems to be well researched and well understood throughout the scientific literature. Meta-analyses such as the one conducted by Jackson, Meyer and Wang (2013) or Schyns and Schilling (2013) showcase that leadership behavior is among the most crucial aspects of contemporary management, which leads to one of the core distinctions. Leadership and management are sometimes equated in layman's everyday language (Kotterman, 2006). However, as the definition of (personnel) management given here shows, they are distinct approaches. It should also be mentioned that while (almost) all leaders are also managers, not all managers are also leaders, i.e. have active leadership responsibility. Management is described as the process of effectively carrying out a company's purpose. For this, management requires the coordination of several steps that typically build on each other.

As this summary shows, leadership can in some respects be understood as a sub-task of management (Weathersby, 1999), which leads back to the above-mentioned assumption: While (almost) all leaders are also managers, the reverse conclusion is not automatically true, as there are also managers who do not take on leadership responsibilities. The aspects mentioned by Weathersby (1999) are also described as a management cycle. In this context, setting goals is the first step, which is then implemented through planning, decision-making, organising and leading. The control of the achievement of objectives is a central aspect: Only if the extent to which the set goals are achieved and whether the steps taken to achieve the goals are adequate are checked can one speak of active management. The last step is the analysis: This is used if the control phase reveals discrepancies or difficulties. The term cycle already implies that these last phase(s) do not represent the end of the process but lead back to the beginning.

Leadership itself happens in a field of tension between different stakeholders - not only the leader and the persons to be led are fundamentally affected by or influence leadership. Rather, it can be supposed - for example, with reference to the model of Becker (2015) - that leadership happens in a complex environment (see also Latham, 2014).

With reference to Figure 1, it can be noted that the characteristic description of leadership primarily represents the top-down process of managing employees. The concept depicted therein is commonly referred to as the core task of leadership and can be seen, for example, in consideration of many success indicators of leadership: the performance, satisfaction and commitment of employees are repeatedly described as central to leadership quality and taken up accordingly (Walumbwa & Hartnell, 2011).

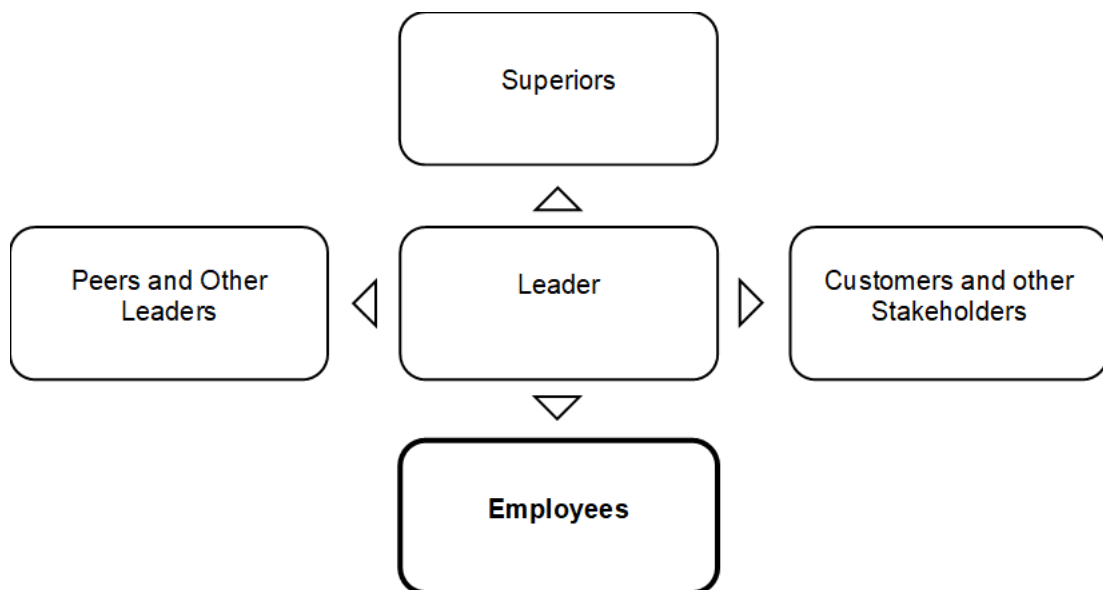


Figure 1. Leadership at the crossroads

However, it must be added that although the other perspectives receive less attention, they can have a great impact on the practical work of a leader (Lee & Farh, 2019). The focus of the present work, however, lays clearly on the relationship between leaders and their employees. While the challenges arising from the set of necessary interactions between leaders and their peers, superiors and other

stakeholders will be addressed throughout this thesis, the centre of attention is shifted towards the relationship between leaders and employees and employees' subsequent commitment to their organization and their leaders.

This implies the lens throughout which the relationship is discussed throughout this thesis: While authors such as Ratten, Ratten, Kim, Yo and James (2011) or Prior (2016) discuss relationship quality as a universal concept that shapes relationships on personal and business-oriented stages, these perspectives are only acknowledged throughout this thesis. The concept of organizational commitment itself stems back to the 1970s, when Mowday, Steers and Porter (1979) explained that the idea of analyzing commitment in order to predict employee behavior is central: "Throughout the various studies, commitment has been repeatedly identified as an important variable in understanding the work behavior of employees in organizations." (Mowday, Steers & Porter, 1979, p. 224).

The popularity of the concept that leads back to earlier conceptualizations under the term *employee loyalty* seems unbroken today, as more recent studies show (Guzeller & Celiker, 2019). In general, it can be observed that two distinct streams of research on organizational commitment seem to exist – one that focuses on the consequences of commitment, where turnover rates or performance measures (see Tett & Meyer, 1993) are used to analyse, how organizational commitment can be used to predict actual employee performance (Guzeller & Celiker, 2019). The other stream of research identified is the one that focuses clearly on the predecessors of organizational commitment and thus on the factors influencing how strong and in which way organizational commitment is experienced by employees (Meyer, Stanley & Parfyonova, 2012). Typical approaches seem to focus on the relationship between organizations (Nongo & Ikyanyon, 2012) or leaders (Mayfield & Mayfield, 2002) and their employees. This is also the gaze that the present research acknowledges and considers, with a focus on the interaction between leaders and their individual employees. Therein lays one of the thesis's central contributions, which acknowledges and assesses the interindividual differences of employees as a

relevant variable that might moderate the relationship between leader behaviour and employee outcomes.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Leadership Research

This section focuses primarily on the perspective of leaders within economic organization. In order to showcase the tasks and responsibilities of leaders, an overview of typical leadership challenges within the contemporary business environment is presented, showing how developments such as the *war for talent* or the increasing digitalization of both the business and societal life can influence the circumstances in which leaders can operate. This subsequently forms the foundation for the depiction of various leadership approaches in section 2.1.3, where the comparison of transformational and transactional leadership styles and other contemporary approaches are presented.

Definitions of Leadership

Leadership describes the act of leading people, Neubauer, Bergner and Felfe (2012) state in the introduction of their work on leadership styles. The nature of leadership thus requires communication both with superiors and subordinates as well as with peers. Leadership occurs in various settings of differing formality, with leadership positions ranging from informal leadership roles in group settings to management directors of multinational companies. Thus, the challenges and requirements posed by leaders vary drastically as well.

One of the core tasks of a leader is to define goals and the mission of an organization and to develop a strategy for how these goals can be reached. Managers, on the other hand, face the task of following and implementing this strategy. The core task of a manager, therefore is, to find solutions for complex but specific problems, whereas leaders have the responsibility to lead the company and its employees on a strategic level in accordance with the leading mission and goal of the company (Kotter, 2008). However, Kotter (2008) also explains that the two terms are often used interchangeably by mistake, as the distinction between choosing the mission and implementing the mission in many cases can be unclear, especially as many

leaders also take on managerial roles and vice versa. Thus, many leaders are also tasked with implementing the strategy and mission, while many managers at the same time are expected to at least support the further development of mission and strategy.

However, the leadership of employees is described to be one of the most important corporate tasks, as Ensley, Hmieleski and Pearce (2006) point out. The authors further accentuate the fact that leadership is not a singular, top-down process within companies. Rather various levels of leadership exist with different types of responsibility and tasks. Thus, roles also exist in which leaders are both leaders and subordinates at the same time, which typically occurs in middle management (Ensley et al., 2006) and has its own challenges (see chapter 2.1.2).

The variety of leadership situations and circumstances, however, also raises the question of what characterizes successful leadership. Zaccaro (2001) argues this on the comparison of top and middle management – while middle management leadership success is often defined by internal parameters such as employee retention or adherence to deadlines, criteria for leaders on top management are usually defined by different key performance indicators. This, the author summarizes, also complicates comparing various scientific results and partially explains why sometimes seemingly contradicting results are found within management literature. Different predictors of success might gain importance depending on the nature of a leader's major challenges and tasks and goals, Zaccaro (2001) summarizes.

Challenges of Leaders

As section 2.1.1 stated, leadership is not a uniform concept that describes a homogenous number of tasks or challenges. Rather, it depends on the leader's role, on his own background and approach, on the situation he is in and on the level of

leadership. As Neubauer, Bergner and Fel-fe (2012) explain, a leader can just as well be a spokesperson of an informal work group that aims to develop a small project of the head of a multinational company. Thus, of course, the challenges leaders are facing, differ as well. However, the subsequent chapters aim to identify a number of challenges that seem to be of high relevance in the contemporary business world and that – as Elkington, Van der Steege, Glick-Smith and Breen (2017) argue – a majority of leaders are facing to various degrees.

War for Talent

It has been proven that satisfied employees perform better, change jobs less often and on average are more willing to do additional work (Gabčanová, 2011). These practical business observations, which are backed up by numerous studies in the areas of business, psychology, and IT, lead to a simple conclusion: To maximize its performance, a company must focus on its employees and their satisfaction. Contrary to popular belief that digitization will result in an enormous loss of jobs and ultimately reduce employees' importance, the opposite is true, the author argues. Rather, high-skilled employees are gaining importance, putting them into a stronger focus of both practitioners and researchers alike.

Above all, highly qualified employees, who are labelled talents by scientists like Ulrich (2008) or Bhattacharya, Sen and Korschun (2008), are in high demand on the employment market. Changes in the workplace increasingly require highly specialized talents to enable a company to compete in an international market - this group of people who are sought tends to move internationally. Regarding modern human or talent management practices, Kane, Palmer, Philips, and Kiron (2017) point out that the War for Talent buzzword was coined in 1998 and is still relevant in human resources practice today.

Due to these developments, employer branding is also one of the core tasks of HR departments. Backhaus and Tikoo (2004) describe that brands are one of the most valuable assets of companies, which makes brand management a core task of

companies. This increasingly applies to HR departments, which are responsible for building an HR-related brand and thus strengthening its attractiveness as an employer. Approaches and approaches from classic brand management are used to make a company seem desirable for potential applicants as well as to bind its own employees more closely to the corporate culture. This coincides with the statements by Swider, Zimmerman and Barrick (2015), which describe that the greatest possible fit should be achieved between the organization and applicants or employees.

Berthon, Ewing and Hah (2005) argue the importance of this type of brand management by saying that the employees are the company's first market: The employees define the success of the company, which means finding the best employees becomes one of the main challenges for contemporary companies. The authors describe that in the past, only traditional job advertisements were relied on in order to find the right applicants for a job.

These communicated - especially in comparison to advertising subjects - clearly and standardized what is offered and needed. It was only in the 1990s that employer branding started to be discussed and elements from marketing and advertising were used to attract potential applicants and present themselves as an attractive employer.

The issue of skill-biased technical change is often discussed against the background of rising unemployment and increasing inequality. However, Mishel, Shierholz and Edwards (2010), for example, make it clear that this fundamental question is not yet a sufficient explanation of the problem of unemployment. On the one hand, they address reasons that can be attributed to a region's economic situation. The authors argue, for example, that the global economic crisis, which was triggered by the bursting of the so-called real estate bubble in the USA, also has an impact on the labour market situation. Not only the crisis itself but also the long-term negative impact on economic development are described as problematic. As a result of the crisis, less is being consumed, which results in a lower demand for labour. At the same

time, however, the authors explain that structural reasons also seem to be partly responsible for the rise in unemployment. This portrayal implies that there seems to exist a disparity between the requirements posed by the labour market and the available competencies and properties among the unemployed population.

Mishel, Shierholz and Edwards (2010) argue that the problem is that those who are unemployed are not well suited to the jobs available. This would be the case, for example, because their qualifications are inadequate, have deteriorated or are not applicable to expanding industries, or because the unemployed simply do not live in the places where the jobs are. Some make assertions about structural unemployment because certain aggregate relationships, such as between job vacancies and unemployment, do not seem to follow historical patterns, suggesting a possible mismatch between qualifications. Others have postulated that employers have significantly transformed their production processes during this downturn, which means that many of the currently unemployed workers are no longer needed.

In summary, the authors stress that the question of what kind of these influences are that lead to unemployment is not a binary one, but rather that both aspects - in an unknown relationship - contribute to the rise in unemployment. Klein (2015), among others, was also concerned with the question of this relationship, investigating the influence of education and training on unemployment rates. In summary, the author concludes that the probability of unemployment decreases significantly with increasing educational attainment. This is particularly true for the situation in Germany. Klein (2015) demonstrates that low-educated people's unemployment rate is the highest in the OECD comparison.

Weiss and Garloff (2011) also discuss the difficulty of the job situation for people with low, inadequate or unsuitable educational experience for the labour market situation. The authors focus on a situation that is referred to in the literature as skill-biased technological change. According to the authors' findings, this development leads to rising unemployment rates, especially in (continental) Europe. According to the theory of skill-biased technological change, changing working conditions and demands on the labour force means that potential workers' skills and educational

indicators are playing an increasingly important role. At the same time, Balleer and Van Rens (2013) argue that jobs that make only low demands on training are losing importance and are partly lost in favour of automation and further development. For people with a low level of education or a lack of skills relevant to the increasingly digitalised and technology-oriented labour market, this increases the probability of (long-term) unemployment.

Authors such as Jaumotte, Lall and Papageorgiou (2013) describe that this development affects the labour market situation in terms of unemployment rates and the general situation on this market. Increasing technologisation and the skill biased technological change described above are the main reasons for the growing inequality in terms of income. Consequently, the income gap is also increasingly diverging among persons in employment.

The skill biased technological change is described as one of the central challenges on the labour market. It impacts the employees (or unemployed) themselves and the companies, which have to face the challenge of having to work more intensively in a market that is dominated by technological change.

Globalization

Organizations operate increasingly in a globalized, international setting – a statement that not only seems true for multinational enterprises but also increasingly for small and medium sized enterprises, who – partially due to the increased digitalization and the subsequently increased capability to operate on such a level – often open up their business approach to a global field (Dana, Etemad & Wright, 1999). It can therefore be argued that the digital transformation (see section 2.1.2.3) offers especially for small and medium sized enterprises the chance, to operate on

an international field, which in turn offers new opportunities on the business side (Autio, Mudambi, & Yoo, 2021; Biggiero, 2006)

This development, however, does not only offer new opportunities but also has implications for leadership and HR management, as Patel, Budhwar, and Chang (2017) explain. Leadership needs to acknowledge the challenge arising from the increasingly internationalized work environment in order to achieve favourable results.

Ambos and Schlegelmilch (2004) describe that today it is hardly possible for companies to acquire their knowledge and know-how only in one country. According to Vollstedt (2002), qualified employees are often no longer to be found in one country. In the area of research and development, in particular, many companies, therefore, rely heavily on the diversification of their structures and thus on international teams. Vollstedt (2002) adds that the cause of international teams is also the different cultural and professional background, which means that the teams have a higher innovation potential to solve problems and accomplish tasks. Von Zedtwitz and Gassmann (2002) similarly describe that companies in research and development are increasingly focusing on internationalization. In doing so, they are trying to take advantage of local innovation advantages to ensure competitiveness in an international market situation. Schneider (1995) describes that the internationalization of the market also means that many companies have to internationalize themselves.

In particular, as Snow, Snell, Davison and Hambrick (1996) argue for international teams and collaborations, the question of corporate culture is a particularly relevant one. In doing so, they primarily address the opportunities for companies that result from such a collaboration: The successful management of such teams can make the corporate culture more international and thus more diversified.

The increasing diversity is also described by Shachaf (2008). Based on 41 expert interviews, the author found that cultural diversity, which can arise through international teamwork, can have positive effects on aspects of corporate culture.

The author reports that this diversity can have a particularly positive effect on decision-making behavior in the company. On the other hand, communication can also have negative influences due to diversity, which, however, only occurs if modern forms of communication (primarily digitized approaches) are avoided. However, if a company increasingly relies on the use of information and communication technologies in team communication, no disadvantage can be seen from the diversity in this regard either.

Schneider (1995) also emphasizes the importance of time for different aspects of working life as a variable, which can be problematic. Using the example of Germany, the researcher explains that career advancement is very strongly correlated with increasing age - which is much less the case in France, for example. There, employees tend to be given more responsibility at a younger age and more attention is paid to the service provided than the time experience.

There are also transcultural differences with regard to the transfer and importance of information. Schneider (1995) describes German employees in such a way that they demand a high level of contextual information in order to feel adequately informed, while this has the opposite effect for the French area - here too much information becomes disruptive or slowdown felt.

The author uses this juxtaposition to explain why conflicts can arise in international teams: Such differences can lead to disputes, especially when an international company tries to establish a dominant lead culture that embraces the cultural aspects of other company areas or cultures involved not considered.

As described by Hofstede (2011), different cultures have different, often opposing characteristics that define the management style, the corporate culture, the strategy and the values of the company. Hofstede proposed to assess cultural peculiarities in six pairs of cultural dimensions, namely: collectivism vs. Individualism, masculinity vs. Femininity, distance of high power vs. Distance of Little Power, Forbearance vs. Reluctance, long-term orientation vs. short-term orientation. Strong against weak uncertainty avoidance. Assessing the company's

cultural diversity based on some clusters of the Hofstede culture model (2011) can give multinational companies valuable insight into existing differences between employees, potential threats due to cultural differences and how they are dealt with (Einarsen, Hoel, Zapf & Cooper, 2011). The approach to power removal - an acceptance of power inequality by members of lower-status society - therefore varies considerably between western and eastern cultures. While a leader's demonstration of power, which is also reflected in bullying and harassment, can be tolerated and accepted as a cultural norm in Asian countries, it is considered unacceptable in Western cultures. Similar problems can arise in cases where cultures with male dominance conflict with those that promote gender equality; or if the approaches to the work process differ significantly in terms of planning and objectives and therefore require greater flexibility and adaptability of the employees (Power et al., 2013). The more points there are for potential cultural conflicts among employees, the greater the likelihood that unethical working methods or conflicts will occur, and the higher the responsibility of management to prevent these methods from occurring (Arnold & Dupré, 2012).

Digital Challenges

Bleicher and Stanley (2016) cite the implementation of digital concepts and the use of digitized, innovative business models as one of the best predictors of the long-term success of companies. The digital revolution, which is described by Bleicher and Stanley (2016) or by Tapscott (1999), not only influences private and business life, but is also the basis for further developments that are related to digitization.

Topol and Hill (2012) particularly mention the intensive use of data - under the keywords "Big Data" and "Data Analytics" as one of the most forward-looking developments of the present. This intensive data use is only possible through many companies' underlying digitalization, which can create a broad data basis. Topol and Hill (2012) cite a wide variety of industries and business sectors as examples of possible areas of application for this data-based approach: the medical sector is

mentioned here as a possible application, as is the insurance industry or the marketing and production departments. Woerner and Wixom (2015) even mention the collection, processing and use of data as one of the central factors of digitization: This allows companies to both foster the general understanding of their relationship with their customers and partners and to better comprehend and subsequently improve their own products and services develop or develop further.

However, for the context of the present thesis, it can be stated that digital transformation does not only affect the business context per se, but also the societal context in which business is typically conducted. Especially members of the younger generations – who increasingly also dominate the employment market – are shaped by their digital experiences, growing up as so-called *digital natives* (Helsper & Enyon, 2010)

These generational developments could strongly influence the market in the coming years, as can be argued with regard to research such as that by Clark (2017). "A generation is defined as a group of individuals born and living contemporaneously who share common knowledge and experiences that affect their thoughts, attitudes, values, beliefs, and behaviours" (Clark, 2017, p. 379). In this context, reference is made to the different living conditions attributed to the respective generations. The Millennial generation, for example, is characterised by increasing digitalisation and the accompanying changes within society. These changes in terms of living conditions and ultimately the reality of life naturally also result in significantly changed values compared to previous generations, as summarised by Krahn and Galambos (2014), for example. Members of this youngest generation, who have grown up in an increasingly digitalised environment, which is also characterised by an increasing degree of globalisation, are also shaped by a corresponding conglomerate of values (Pendergast, 2010). This differs significantly from that of other generations, similar to how values differ in relation to different national or regional cultures.

Therein lies one of the overlapping factors between the aforementioned description of globalization and digital developments. As Weber (2017) explains, the

increasing digital transformation in regards to lifestyle and society also implies an increase in globalized communication and collaboration, which, therefore, partially minimizes cultural differences between individual regions. Thus, the question can be raised, whether the study of cultural differences and their impact on leadership behavior – or, subsequently, the impact of leadership behavior on employees of different cultures – will be impacted by this development (see section 2.1.2.2). At the same time, Weber (2017) argues that cultural differences between generations seem to continue growing in relevance. This trend and the subsequent influence of digital developments seem to increase in light of the Covid-19 crisis.

The Covid 19 crisis led to increased digitalisation at both the business and societal levels (Hantrais et al., 2020; Tsekeris & Mastrogeorgiou, 2020), reflected for example in digital learning experiences (Mulenga & Marban, 2020) and digitalised modes of workplace collaboration (Belzunegui-Eraso & Erro-Garcés). Although such working models - as summarised by Schur, Ameri and Kruse (2020) under the term telework - do not represent a fundamental novelty, the pandemic and the social and physical distancing measures taken in the context of it led to a rapid increase in corresponding usage habits (Dubey & Tripathi, 2020). This depiction is also echoed in regards to the consequences for human resource management (HRM), which on the one hand, has to react to these internal reactions with suitable measures and, on the other hand, is itself faced with the challenge of increasingly digitising its own processes (Caligiuri, De Cieri, Minbaeva & Zimmermann, 2020; Przytuła, Strzelec, & Krysińska-Kościańska, 2020).

This double burden of the HRM function is also discussed comparably in the pre-covid context: Thite (2018) or Parry and Strohmeier (2014) explain that it is of fundamental relevance for HR departments to be the driving force behind the digital transformation of the company and at the same time also to expand their own department in a digital way. In this context, Furtmueller, Wilderom and Tate (2011) mention, for example, digital strategies for personnel acquisition, which represent

not only the use of social media for recruitment but also digital approaches to structuring and optimising the recruitment process itself. HR development, which is also presented as an increasingly important instance of HR (Dash, Farooq, Panda & Sandhyavani, 2019), must also face up to the demands of digitalisation. On the one hand, these require a more rapid change in the necessary skills and abilities of employees, which must be responded to with increasingly complex strategies for recording the necessities and managing them. At the same time, Mihalcea (2017) and Bondarouk and Ruël (2009) argue that the modern business environment's complexity is making non-digital HR and talent management strategies increasingly obsolete or unfeasible.

This development now seems to have been significantly accelerated by the Covid 19 crisis with its tendency towards the (prescribed) use of digital collaboration models (Waizenegger, McKenna, Cai & Bendz, 2020). This paper deals with the resulting field of tension for human resources management, with a particular focus on one aspect of its activities. The on-boarding of employees is understood by Klaffke (2014), for example, as a central activity in the context of management and leadership: It is, as it were, the interface between recruitment and human resource development and one of the earliest opportunities to foster the bond between companies and employees (Jansen, Odoni & Wombacher, 2019; Snell, 2006). As Wallace, de Chernatony and Buil (2013) argue, fostering this bond is generally described as one of the most relevant tasks of modern leaders and HR management, as strong employee retention is linked to a variety of desirable goals for organisations. Employees who are more loyal to the company tend to perform significantly better, are more willing to work harder (Ali, Rehman, Ali, Yousaf & Zia, 2010; Bishop, Scott & Burroughs, 2000) and are less likely to consider changing jobs or companies (Karsh, Booske & Sainfort, 2005). Accordingly, companies must succeed in establishing a stable relationship with employees already in this early interaction phase of on-boarding. Cable, Gino and Staats (2013) explain in this context that not only professional but also organisational and cultural aspects should be conveyed in the context of this process, which can increase the long-term relationship.

A special case of on-boarding is the digital approach. This seems to be a relevant development especially in the context of prescribed teleworking (Waizenegger et al., 2020) but also against the background of the general trend towards digital types of collaboration, as Chillakuri (2020) or Kaur (2018) note. On the one hand, this can be utilized to approach the change in values mentioned by Klaffke (2014) and the demand for digital strategies and measures, which is mainly expressed by the younger generation. According to Payton (2015), the younger generation increasingly wants the digital transformation to influence company processes more and further shape the culture there. On the other hand, this approach can also be seen as a reaction to the changed working conditions and thus as a necessary change (Myers & Sadaghiani, 2010; Schroth, 2019).

In this context, there seem to be at least basic findings that such an approach can lead to positive results, although with reference to the findings of Thums and Müller (2019) it must also be mentioned that the perspective of the employees seems to be central as a basis for evaluation. At the same time, however, it must be emphasised that little seems to be known about the actual implementation of digital on-boarding strategies. In particular, with reference to Kaur (2018) and Thite (2018), it should be noted here that a variety of different tools and models seem to be united under the collective term of digital on-boarding.

Integrity

Engelbrecht, Heine and Mahembe (2017) define integrity as the “adherence to moral principles” (p. 368). Integrity influences the trust employees place in their organisations and leaders, the authors state. As such, integrity was proposed to be a part of leadership personality. McCann, Sparks and Kohntopp (2017) explain that the general measurement of (leadership) integrity follows two separate approaches, typically. The first approach describes “integrity as consistency with integrity defined by the belief that values are applied consistently” (McCann, Sparks &

Kohntopp, 2017, p. 179). The second approach, the authors further explain, argues that moral values form the foundation for integrity. The different approaches towards measuring integrity are also summarized by Palanski and Yammarino (2007, p. 171): “too many definitions, too little theory, and too few rigorous empirical studies.” The first two problems, however, the authors argue, are the main reason for the third problem: as definitions vary strongly from each other, clear empirical approaches are difficult to undertake, leading to a lack of comparable results. As most research works on the topic use different definitions of what constitutes integrity, projects like systematic overviews or meta-analyses are difficult to conduct, the authors argue. However, contemporary research on the topic showcases that the relevance of the topic, despite its difficult delimitation, seems to be on the rise, as Engelbrecht, Heine and Mahembe (2017) show in regards to the relationship between integrity-driven leadership behavior and employee-related outcomes. Their empirical results indicate that leaders who are perceived by their employees as of integrity and as ethical, are also trusted more strongly and willingly by their employees, leading to more favourable relationships between them: “mutual trust and employee engagement will strengthen when integrity behaviour and ethical leadership are present in the work environment.” (Engelbrecht, Heine & Mahembe, 2017, p. 377). In the same context, authors such as Brown and Trevino (2006) propose an approach described as *ethical leadership*, which focuses on a similar goalsetting: By addressing the need for trustworthiness and integrity, leaders should in general act in an ethical way, Brown and Trevino (2006) argue, which implies following not only legal frameworks but *going above and beyond* these in order to benefit not only the financial bottom line but also society as a whole (see section 2.1.2.5). this development – and the subsequently described focus on socially responsible firm behaviour – is described by the authors to be partially a response to contemporary developments in the business world: “Following Enron and other recent ethics scandals in business, government, sports, non-profits, and even religious organizations, people are asking, what is wrong with our leaders?” (Brown & Trevino, 2006, p. 595)

Environmental Issues & CSR

With the growing importance of social responsibility for companies, dealing with their stakeholders also plays an increasingly central role (Mesciek, 2016). Stakeholders are all groups and individuals who can influence the company or are affected by corporate decisions (Jonker, Stark & Tewes, 2011). Companies have a responsibility to their stakeholders, which include, for example, customers, suppliers, employees, owners, capital providers, but also non-market stakeholders such as the state or the public (Zirnig, 2008; Dubielzig & Schaltegger, 2005).

In addition to the CSR concept, which deals with the question of what social responsibility a company should assume, the stakeholders focus on the aspect of who should be responsible for it. Therefore, the two concepts are closely related in theory and in practical implementation in companies (Altenburger, 2016).

In many companies, CSR is a reaction to the expectations, wishes and, in some cases, pressure from various stakeholders (Jonker, Stark & Tewes, 2011). Stakeholders no longer only demand economic aspects from the company, but increasingly also social and environmental aspects, since they are affected by the effects of CSR. With the required orientation towards Corporate Social Responsibility, stakeholders are trying to ensure that companies voluntarily incorporate social and ecological demands into their business activities and their interaction with stakeholders. Consequently, CSR serves the company to meet its obligations and responsibilities towards its stakeholders with regard to sustainability (Dubielzig & Schaltegger, 2005).

For a long time, it was assumed that companies had to choose between economic success and the assumption of responsibility, as these are contradictory. In the meantime, many practical examples and scientific studies show that it is possible to embed both aspects in corporate strategy and that corporate social responsibility can even positively influence the financial success of companies (Schneider & Schmidpeter, 2014).

Internationally operating companies are involved in corporate social responsibility for various reasons. The companies state that these reasons are mainly based

on reputational gains and the improvement of stakeholder relations. In the first place, however, companies argue that they use social responsibility to ensure their own future viability and improve their medium to long-term economic situation, as this is fundamental to the company's profitability (Kirchhoff, 2006).

With the Business Case for CSR, companies aim to assume social responsibility on the one hand, but also to do business in an economically sensible way on the other.

Empirical studies have shown that the assumption of social responsibility by a company's environmental management can lead to an increased identification with the company and can positively influence current and potential employees. In addition, high environmental standards can positively impact various organizational outcomes such as efficiency and the ability of a firm to foster innovation and achieve a positive reputation with customers. A positive reputation of the customer, in turn, can be reflected in an increased willingness to pay. It is also possible that the capital markets will reward environmental services with lower capital costs (Schreck, 2015).

Companies that act responsibly are economically more successful in the long term because by looking at the environment and their fellow human beings and by addressing issues of social interest, a company becomes more sustainable, as it can anticipate trends and problems in its environment more attentively and quickly and can thus include these in its strategic considerations. On the other hand, economic success is also the necessary prerequisite for the future-proof perception of social responsibility. Only companies that are internationally competitive and economically sound can be in a position to contribute to the solution of social problems.

It can therefore be stated that corporate social responsibility, on the one hand, and the economic performance of a company, on the other hand, are linked. CSR is the necessary complement to the shareholder value strategy and includes it in a detailed concept of corporate policy that gives equal consideration to all stakeholders. To ensure the company's future viability, it needs a strategic combination of shareholder value and social responsibility, because only if a company generates

corresponding returns is it able to meet the interests of its employees, society, and the environment (Kirchhoff, 2006).

The concept of CSR was first introduced around 70 years ago with a steadily growing interest both by practitioners and researchers in the topic, as Moir (2001) explains. Research associated with CSR covers today a wide range of scientific disciplines with a major focus on the field of economics. Dahlsrud (2008, p. 1) noted in regard to the growing popularity of the CSR concept: "The corporate world is facing the notion of corporate social responsibility (CSR), wherever it turns these days." Whereas in the early years and decades of the introduction of the concept of CSR to the business world, it was viewed as an exotic new approach, today it seems – as Dahlsrud (2008) states, a major aspect of contemporary business environments.

Bowen and Johnson (1953), however, were among the first researchers to define the meaning of CSR that went on to influence the later development of the concept. In their 1953 book called *Social Responsibilities of the Businessman* the authors define CSR: "It refers to the obligations of businessmen to pursue those policies, to make those decisions, or to follow those lines of action which are desirable in terms of the objectives and values of our society." (Bowen & Johnson, 1953, as cited by Bowen, 2013, p.6).

Before this impactful book, Van Marrewijk (2003) argues, the modern CSR concept did not exist in this form. Similar approaches were typically known as social responsibility and largely ignored the societal role modern corporations hold. Thus, socially responsible behaviour was, Van Marrewijk (2003) further states, rather an idea for private individuals than for corporations.

Johnston, Everard, Santillo and Robèrt (2007) complain that one of the basic problems in describing sustainability lies in the diversity of different definitions. This means that sustainability has very different meanings for different people, which makes comparative studies or critical analyses of different approaches difficult. However, the probably most comprehensive and widespread definition is the

one that was established in 1987 in the context of the Brundtland Report and which should form the basis for most of the work on sustainability: "Sustainability is development that meets the needs of present generations without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their needs" (Brundtland Commission, 1987, p. 43).

The concept of sustainability is closely related to that of corporate social responsibility. However, it focuses primarily on social aspects of business life and the responsible treatment of relevant stakeholders such as employees, customers and the general public (O'Riordan & Fairbrass, 2008). Sustainability itself, however, also clearly focuses on the ecological area and should therefore form an important aspect of any development task, as recommended by Baden and Harwood (2013).

The introduction to this section has already made it clear that the field of sustainability, more comprehensive than that of Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR), has several core areas. The so-called triple bottom approach is followed, which describes that sustainability consists of three pillars: Economic efficiency or ecology, social and economic aspects (Elkington, 1998).

These three pillars also make it clear that sustainability must be deeply rooted in companies to ensure successful implementation (see Section 2.3). While aspects of ecology, for example, are sensibly anchored in production or development departments, the social aspect of sustainability is often located in HR. There, the idea of sustainable HR management represents a new approach, which envisages that HR management should no longer be detached from companies' real work, as Ulrich (1998) describes it, but should act as strategic partners within the company.

This is also taken up by representatives of modern, sustainable HR management, who see HR as the focus of the company (Kramar, 2014). While the topic of "sustainability" has become increasingly important in both the scientific and public debate, sustainable HR management is still a comparatively young field (Kramar, 2014). It is closely related on the one hand to the field of corporate social responsibility, i.e. the socially responsible management of a company, or to the field of sustainable leadership (Avery, 2005).

Elkington (1998) describes basic recommendations for implementing the triple bottom approach to sustainability. In particular, the author relies on the networking approach of sustainability: in order to have a sustainable effect, cooperation within the company is just as important as cooperation with external stakeholders. In the context of sustainability, not only shareholders, financiers or customers are regarded as such external stakeholders, but also NGOs, the population itself and, in the broadest sense, future generations (Elkington, 1998, p. 51). Finding the right partners and building a relationship of trust with them thus become core challenges for companies.

Elkington (1998, p. 50) also emphasises that the development of ecologically efficient and sustainable management tools also requires that they be made visible to the outside world and developed together with stakeholders. These - according to the author - increasingly demand sustainable developments and a responsible approach to the environment.

Lee and Vachon (2016) discuss that sustainability is not only a task of social importance but can also be of outstanding importance for the company itself, using risk management and public relations as examples.

The media play a central role in the scandalisation of misconduct. They are the source from which the public usually learns about possible corporate misconduct and the media forms the sphere in which corporate behaviour is evaluated, criticised, and discussed (Thiessen, 2011). However, it is not only the company's decisions and actions that are relevant to public perception but also the actions of its suppliers (see Figure 2), which can be regarded as an important part of the organization due to their complex relationship with the Group. Multinational companies and brands face a major challenge in managing their reputational risk due to the need to control this additional party. According to the model, the (management) behaviour of a supplier can lead to damage to the multinational company's reputation and consequently to financial losses. Lee and Vachon (2016) cite companies such as

Nike, BP, and Nestlé as examples of cases where a negative public perception of the supply chain influences companies.

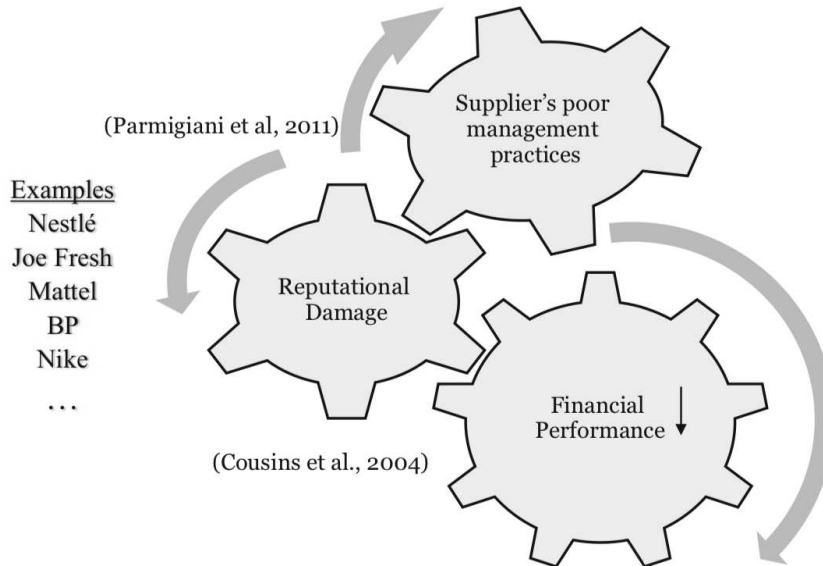


Figure 2. Reputational damages (Lee & Vachon, 2014, p. 246)

According to Lee and Vachon (2016), problems in the supply chain can range from child labour or environmental scandals to inadequate working conditions or tax fraud. In particular, they emphasize the violation of standards by companies and their suppliers, which, following the differentiation of Deephouse and Carter (2005), speak more for the damage to legitimacy than reputation. As a result of the violation of legal and, in this example, above all ethical standards, society's expectations of the company are no longer fulfilled, which leads to a loss of legitimacy. For the supplier companies themselves, the damage to their image is often not clearly visible. As they are often not known to the public, the public and media perception of corresponding scandals is concentrated on the group which appears in public. In the course of the public crisis, companies are therefore under pressure to justify their misconduct to the public (Thiessen, 2011) and try to avert a possible crisis and/or find a way to deal with it.

Risks, crises and their management approaches

Crisis management comprises the prevention, recognition and management of a crisis. Risk management as part of internal crisis management forms the basis of successful crisis management. On the one hand, it can minimise the probability of corporate crises occurring in advance and, on the other hand, it allows the right precautions to be taken for the tools of crisis management (Schawel & Billing, 2017). Schawel and Billing (2017) stress the importance of early detection of a crisis, as success can depend on it. Crisis management can be carried out actively to avoid crises or reactively to manage the crisis. Risk management therefore allows companies either to avoid crises from the outset or be prepared for them to be better managed (Schawel & Billing, 2017).

Crisis communication as external crisis management plays a central role in the repair of legitimacy and deals with the interaction between organisations and external stakeholders (Pearson & Clair, 1998). The involvement of relevant stakeholders plays a central role and is also a major challenge (Thiessen, 2014). This is in line with stakeholder management approaches, which emphasize that modern companies must not only be guided by the requirements of their investors but must also involve other stakeholders in their strategy. These include Thiessen (2014) not only customers and suppliers but also the company's own workforce, which can be affected by crises and whose reaction to these crises can influence the progress of the crisis. Accordingly, and in keeping with the complexity of modern companies described by Pearson and Clair (1998), Thiessen (2014) emphasizes the importance of postmodern crisis management. Postmodern crisis management's main task is to develop practicable and sensible solutions and create new approaches. Thus, the author emphasizes that the reaction to crises should not be based on tried and tested patterns of action, but should instead create and consolidate new ones. At the same time, it is emphasized that a crisis strategy must always be oriented towards the crisis itself, which makes standard strategies much more difficult. While it is

important to have appropriate approaches ready, these must be adapted to the respective situation and the stakeholders involved (Thiessen, 2014). This is also reflected in the tasks that modern crisis communication has to fulfil in comparison to classical approaches. The repair of a damaged image - for example, due to a norm violation - is one of the central tasks of crisis communication or crisis management (Benoit, 1997). Benoit (1997) understands communication as a response to situations which are characterized by two problems: The accused is held responsible for an action. This action is described as a violation of the norm. According to Benoit (1997), it is less important to deal with the crisis situation or the phase of the crisis than to consider the response options. The author also presents recommendations for crisis communication. These are preceded by the importance of precise preparation, which in the best case is carried out before the actual crisis occurs. This seems particularly important since many crises that affect legitimacy or reputation require rapid action. The fact that there is not one correct approach for all situations is also reflected in the next recommendations: The nature of the crisis and the allegations should be identified as well as the target audience of the crisis communication. Depending on the outcome of this analysis process, different strategies can be useful for a company.

Diversity

Köllen (2019) describes diversity management as a historically evolved approach that is becoming increasingly relevant in industrialised, western ecosystems as well as in emerging economic environments. However, the author describes the problem that neither diversity nor diversity management seems to have clear and generally accepted definitions as a fundamental challenge for both science and practice. According to Köllen (2019), this complicates both the practical implementation of programmes and the scientific discourse on their effectiveness. Added to this is the fact that the topic is also shaped by ideological and political aspects, which

makes a purely business-oriented view difficult or even pointless: "Diversity management did not completely distance itself from the professed morality of striving for equality, but equality in this context had more the status of a desirable, unquestioned, and welcome side effect of its anticipated economic impact" (Köllen, 2019, p. 1).

Different approaches to diversity management are also subject to a fundamental development in the context of the *zeitgeist*, as Ashikali and Groeneveld (2015) note. Early programmes and approaches followed the concept of affirmative action, for example, or focused purely on quota regulations. These purely indicator-based approaches attempted to create the best possible equal opportunities for minorities and women. However, this perspective is viewed critically in recent research, as Ashikali and Groeneveld (2015) or Herring and Henderson (2012) note. At the same time, however, it can be emphasised that these early approaches certainly served to influence the consideration of diversity and the treatment of minorities in general (Herring/Henderson, 2012). At the same time, however, the debate on affirmative action and mandatory quota regulations in particular also shaped public discourse to some extent, which led to partly negative attitudes within the population towards the topic itself: "For some people, the term 'diversity' provokes intense emotional reactions because it brings to mind such politically charged ideas as 'affirmative action' or 'quotas'. The idea of diversity is ambiguous, and this ambiguity is expressed in the variety of the concept's definitions that exist in the literature" (Herring/Henderson, 2012, p. 630).

Jordan (2011), for example, emphasises that a fundamental distinction can be made between a diversity-based and an inclusion-based approach. While the former approach - according to the author - focuses primarily on the management of differences, the more contemporary approach of inclusion management is primarily geared towards creating commonalities. Typically, however, a difference-oriented approach is chosen in companies, the author criticises with regard to the corresponding effects: "While diversity in organisations is increasingly respected as a fundamental characteristic, neither acceptance nor appreciation have equated to

inclusive workplaces where unique vantage points of diverse people are valued" (Jordan, 2011, p. 2). 2) According to Shore, Randel, Chung, Dean, Holcombe-Ehrhart and Singh (2011), this approach, which focused on challenges and problems in particular - and discussed quota systems as a central management option - also shaped the academic discourse of diversity research for a long time. Accordingly, a more modern framework would primarily explore or enable different approaches to inclusion, as the authors' framework (see Table 1) makes clear.

Table 1. Framework of inclusion

		Low Belongingness	High Belongingness
Value in Uniqueness	Low Value in Uniqueness	Exclusion Individual is not treated as an organizational insider with unique value in the work group but there are other employees or groups who are insiders.	Assimilation Individual is treated as an insider in the work group when they conform to organizational/dominant culture norms and downplay uniqueness.
	High Value in Uniqueness	Differentiation Individual is not treated as an organizational insider in the work group but their unique characteristics are seen as valuable and required for group/ organization success.	Inclusion Individual is treated as an insider and also allowed/encouraged to retain uniqueness within the work group.

According to the authors, such a systematic approach allows for a classification of different approaches and makes the associated challenges visible at the corporate level. Therefore, it is one of the fundamental tasks of modern leadership to promote this very inclusion and thus contribute to a working environment that is perceived as conducive by all participants (Brimhall, MorBarak, Hurlburt, McArdle, Palinkas and Henwood (2017).

A particular challenge with regard to managing diversity or dealing with diversity is described for multinational companies, which typically operate in an environment of different mentalities, cultures, ethical norms and leadership approaches (Kercher, 2007, p. 6906). In this regard, reference can be made, for example, to the concept of cultural dimensions developed by Hofstede (2011), which assumes that cultures can be classified on the basis of several dimensions. According to Hofstede (2011), this classification system can be applied as a tool to show the cultural distance between different cultures, a depiction which in turn can be used to manage corresponding differences.

As described by Kercher (2007, p. 6906) as special challenges for diversity management, multinational companies are characterised by the fact that they operate in sometimes very different cultures, which requires a corresponding strategy within the overall company to manage them accordingly. According to Kapoor and Sherif (2012, p. 1625f), the typically great diversity in terms of ethnicities, religions and age distribution in such companies is an aspect that must be addressed accordingly by managers.

Diversity, which as described above can bring with it a multitude of advantages, also harbours potential for conflict, as Bagshaw, Lepp and Zorn (2007, p. 433f) emphasise. In particular, international collaborations or those characterised by different cultural backgrounds of the team members are considered a challenge for these teams' management. In this regard, it should be mentioned that although conflicts cannot be avoided in all cases, their fundamental management is one of the main challenges in the field of leadership and project management (Abiodun, 2014, p. 118f).

Intercultural teams in particular face the problem of a tendency towards increased conflict potential. Here, as in other teams, not only do interindividual differences arise as potential conflicts, but also those that are shaped by cultural differences between people and the associated different expectations of activity, cooperation and leadership (Kirzner, 1997, p. 61). Although diversity itself does not

directly and inevitably lead to conflicts, as Kirzner (1997) concludes, it does increase the probability that such conflicts will occur.

Types of Leadership

This section aims to showcase various approaches towards leadership. On the one hand, the selection here follows the initial research question, which mostly aims to foster an understanding of transformational leadership's relevance for organizational commitment. However, on the other hand, other relevant approaches to leadership are presented to offer an overview of the embodiment of leadership studies.

Transformational – Transactional

Judge and Piccolo (2004) explain that the concept of transactional leadership - and with it the difference to transformational leadership - first received attention in the late 1970s and then more deeply in the 1980s. According to Judge and Piccolo (2004), transactional managers concentrate their leadership activities on the exchange of resources, i.e. they offer their employees something they want in return for corresponding benefits. Accordingly, the transactional management of employees and managers or companies is at the centre of transactional leadership: work performance is exchanged for rewards (Judge & Piccolo, 2004).

However, as defined by Bass, Avolio, Jung and Berson (2003), transactional leadership focuses in particular on the aspect of reward and punishment, as they occur in the context of interaction at the company level. The basic assumption of this leadership approach is that people are particularly willing to perform if they receive the corresponding reward for actually doing so. Such a reward is typically understood as a bonus, which the manager awards to the employees for successful performance (Hater & Bass, 1988). However, the authors also point out that an ongoing employment relationship can generally be regarded as a transaction in the sense of this leadership model: as long as an employee is in such an employment

relationship, a transaction takes place independently of the payment of a bonus, which in the sense of this leadership approach should serve to increase the motivation of the employees. A transactional manager's task is thus to create a system of rewards (or punishments) that seems fundamentally suited to getting employees to complete the desired tasks to their full satisfaction (Odumeru & Ogbonna, 2013; MacKenzie, Podsakoff, Rich, 2001).

On the other hand, transformational leadership relies instead on offering meaning and purpose: transformational leaders promote the relationship between employees and the respective organization and attach importance to combining the motivation of the company and the motivation of the employees (Judge & Piccolo, 2004). An early definition of transformational leadership is presented by Burns (1978, p. 20), who described a leader following this approach as one who “engages with others in such a way that the leader and the follower raise one another to a higher level of motivation and morality” (Burns, 1978, p. 20). However, this early depiction of transformational leadership did not focus foremost on leadership in the organizational context, Andersen (2018) argues, but rather as a general leadership perspective. It was Bass (1985) who – according to Andersen (2018) – applied the principles described by Burns (1978) to the business and organizational context and thus connected the leadership approach itself with organizational outcomes. Also, Bass (1985) applied a distinct definition towards the concept of transformational leadership, that Andersen (2018) summarizes as the four pillars of transformational leadership: “four dimensions: idealized influence, individualised consideration, inspirational motivation and intellectual stimulation.” (Andersen, 2018, p. 767).

The four dimensions of transformational leadership are also acknowledged by other researchers in the field, such as Bono and Judge (2004), who label the *idealized influence* as an approach of “high standards of moral and ethical conduct” (p. 901). “Transformational leaders also typically follow an approach described as *inspirational motivation*. One of the core goals of transformational leaders, thus, is to inspire employees and to motivate them, by making them believe in the goals of the

company and pushing them towards actively *wanting* to contribute to the success.” (Meixner & Pospíšil, 2020). Further, the act of intellectual stimulation, as Andersen (2018) or Bono and Judge (2004) describe it based on early writings of Bass (1985), has to be mentioned as a critical aspect of transformational leaders, who “challenge organizational norms, encourage divergent thinking, and who push followers to develop innovative strategies” (Bono & Judge, 2004, p. 901) and “also focus on the individual growth of employees (*individual consideration*)” (Meixner & Pospíšil, 2020).

Transformational leadership, therefore, authors such as Mandell and Pherwani (2003) argue, leads the focus away from the transactional approach and shifts it towards the relationship quality and the interaction between the leader and the employees. Whereas transactional leadership aims to create a framework of rewarding and punishing conditions and rules or guidelines that explain which employee actions are to be rewarded or to be apprehended, the transformational approach instead aims to create a system of communication and interaction and thus a certain working atmosphere that is intended to foster employees’ loyalty and commitment to the organization. Therefore, the authors further argue that it is a transformational leader’s main task to establish a connection between the employees’ needs and values on the one hand and the values and requirements of the organization on the other hand. Establishing such a connection is therefore crucial for leadership success and subsequently for performance outcomes. Men (2014) argues that this can typically be achieved through positive communication techniques, highlighting the high relevance of leadership communication in the framework of transformational leadership, where an emotional relationship between the leader (or the organization) and the employees is to be created.

Optimally, this is achieved through the use of positive communication, with which the manager succeeds in communicating these values and at the same time understanding and taking into account the needs of the employees (Men, 2014). This leadership approach creates an emotional relationship between the leader (or the company) and the employees (Mandell & Pherwani, 2003).

While early differentiations regarded these two leadership approaches as two ends of the same spectrum, i.e. as contrary, Bass (1985) showed that they are rather two largely independent leadership approaches, which can also coincide to varying degrees. According to Bass (1999), a manager can use both transactional and transformational approaches simultaneously. Transactional approaches serve to enable the managed employees to fulfil their own interests by, for example, obtaining a reward, while transformational approaches try to get the employees to act beyond their own motives.

The different leadership approaches are critically discussed Dubinsky, Yammarino, Jolson and Spangler (1995). The authors contrast transformational leadership with (older) transactional leadership. They define transactional leadership as a transaction between employer and employees: if employees show successful performances, they are rewarded within the organizational context, thus implying a transaction between employees and employers. One of the main tasks of transactional leaders is, therefore, the introduction and implementation of rewarding systems. However, the authors point out that transactional leadership is not to be viewed as an opposing approach to transformational leadership. Rather, as Bass (1985) also points out, both leadership styles can appear at the same time and independently from each other.

LJI – Lock – Model

Adams (2007) states that optimal leadership styles can hardly be classified as stable occurrence in times with quickly changing circumstances and environments. Rather, the author talks about wisdom in leadership, by which he explains the flexibility to change the leadership style and approach in regards to the situation, the environment and the person being led. Adam, therefore, concludes that the most

successful leader should be the one who can – wisely – chose between different leadership styles and can change his approach according to the requirements of the situation.

Neubauer, Bergner and Felfe (2012) argue in a similar vein that some leaders might have strongly preferred leadership styles that they might use independent of the situation (either willingly and consciously or sub-consciously), whereas other leaders possess the ability to react in a more flexible way to the changing circumstances. The authors are thereby referencing the leadership model *Formula 4* that was first introduced by Vroom and Yetton (1973).

In which situations managers should rather decide alone (directive) and when it would be better to involve employees in the decision-making process (participatory) was also the central question of Vroom and Yetton (1973). Their model represents an essential basis for the Leadership Judgement Indicator that was developed by Neubauer, Bergner and Felfe (2012). It takes up aspects of management style approaches and situational approaches, which is why the question of employee involvement is also addressed here. The question of which approach to use is not answered in general, but rather depending on the situation (see also Vroom & Jago, 2007). Important situational components are, for example, whether sufficient time is available or whether the decision is clear, or its quality is ensured by the involvement of the employees can be improved. A further point concerns the acceptance of the decision. For example, if the successful implementation of a decision is dependent on it is active support by the employees, it is important that the employees are notified in advance.

Comparable to the normative decision model, according to Vroom and Yetton (1973), the Formula 4 model of leadership is based on the assumption that the most essential activity of an executive is in the making of decisions. To optimize decision-making processes, the decision behaviour must vary depending on the situational circumstances and it must must always be considered anew how strongly the employees in the respective decision-making process should be involved. Depending on the situation, it may be suitable to enter into a democratic decision-making

process with the employees or make independent and authoritarian decisions as a manager. Based on the Formula 4 model, this approach can be utilized to determine the extent to which a manager recognises the correct level of employee participation in upcoming decisions. In addition, the model provides a diagnostic statement on the extent to which managers can make decisions about various decision situations, although their individual decision and behavioral preferences can adapt to specific situation requirements. In contrast to the normative decision model according to Vroom and Yetton, the Formula 4 approach is more pragmatic and combines four different management styles, which can be further differentiated if required can.

Middle Management

Today, communication and a communication-oriented leadership style are described by many scientific authors such as Doppler and Lauterburg (2008) as the central predictor of leadership success. Typically, however, research on leadership and leadership communication puts an emphasis on top management levels of leadership, as they are often deemed to be the main creators of innovation and thus the ones responsible for corporate success. This view, however, has led to the situation that the role of leaders in middle management and their influence on corporate success has been widely neglected both in leadership research and practice, as Sidhu (2016) points out. Sidhu (2016) explains that while a majority of important corporate decisions are taken at the strategically oriented top management level, their success of implementation typically depends strongly on middle-managements involvement and success. The adaption and acceptance of new strategies and their subsequent transformational power are decided not only on the strategic but also on the tactical and operational level of companies, Sidhu (2016) argues.

One of the first researchers recognized to be active in fostering understanding of various management levels is Porter (1963). He prominently studies the (psychological) needs of leaders at different management levels. One of his core findings was

that leaders in top-level positions named self-realization and autonomy as their strongest needs. This, Porter (1963) further showed, was one of the core differentiations between top-level and middle- or lower-level leadership positions. At these levels, different goals were more prominently described by leaders. This finding from Porter (1963) is in partial alignment with more recent findings like the ones by Lubatkin, Schweiger and Weber (1999), who also point out that top managers display a very high degree of autonomy. However, recent findings like the ones from Wooldridge, Schmid and Floyd (2008) also point out that the need for higher autonomy also is becoming more crucial in middle management positions. The authors described this development based on a general change in values, as the work of Klaffke (2014) also describes (see chapter 2.1.2.3).

These recent research results in terms of generational changes are of double importance for the consideration of middle management levels and their communication methods and challenges: On the one hand, a large number of members of these management levels themselves are shaped by the socialization circumstances described by Klaffke (2014), on the other hand, their communication recipients are very strongly influenced by these values and developments as well. This makes leadership positions in middle management levels into important communication interfaces that are also important for the inter-generational exchange, as Klaffke (2014) describes it: on the one hand, information and instructions are received by leaders in these positions in a way that often does not meet their own demands or requirements and is only partially aligned to their values. On the other hand, they are responsible for passing this information and instruction on to their own subordinates, which typically involves a process of transformation, partially due to the typical generational gap found between top management executives and employees.

The difficulties that can be associated with this key position are highlighted by Sims (2003). The author describes that middle managers find themselves in a difficult position when they have to prove themselves to three different audiences in creating a leadership narrative: their superiors, their subordinates and themselves. Sims explains that one of a leader's tasks is to create a narrative that enables

subordinates to believe in the task or the entire leadership situation. At the same time, it is leaders' task to narratively communicate their own performance as well as that of their employees to their own superiors. Sims describes the challenge as being neither only a part of the story determined by others nor in the stronger position of a senior manager whose stories and descriptions are considered more inviolable. This puts them in a difficult position with regard to their own self-perception: the narrative they use in order to lead must be coherent enough to be believed in by themselves, stirring enough to convince the employees and at the same time remain consistent with the stories, narratives and ideas of top management.

The influence of middle management in leadership success is also described in a different way by Beck and Plowman (2009), who refer here to the learning of organisations. The learning of an organisation is today seen as a core task of a modern company (Brown & Duguid, 2000), which can decide on a company's success. Thus, organizational learning is also described as a central challenge for managers in strategic areas (Vera & Crossan, 2004). Crossan, Lane and White (1999) also describe Organizational Learning as an important task of a company, whereby it is particularly emphasized that it is a challenge for corporate communication. The basis of a learning organisation is a networked organisation that comprehensively understands the corresponding communication across the levels and thus brings the employees and their knowledge closer to the decision-makers at the management levels. This also brings middle-level managers to the fore as important communicators. The authors Beck and Plowman (2009) describe as a difficulty for companies the learning from rare and unexpected events, which are difficult for companies to interpret. At the same time, however, such events can have serious (positive and negative) consequences, which is why preparing for such singular events would be of great interest to many companies. Middle management plays an important role here: While upper management is often too far away from the operational level to notice small changes, middle management is more involved in these processes and

should therefore have fewer difficulties in interpretation. As a result, people in this middle management level are once again in a significant role of the company as mediators between the levels. While classical management tasks, as described above, often involve top-down communication, organisational learning can also involve communication in the other direction. This is again a communication process (Beck & Plowman, 2009).

Leadership & HR-Management

HR-Management (HRM) and leadership partially share similar challenges and aim to fulfil similar goals. The importance of HR departments actually being deeply involved in companies is emphasized by Kramar (2014), among others: Sustainable, modern HR policy must be deeply rooted in the company so that relevant decisions are not limited to the HR department itself. This results in an intensive, complex networking of the HR function with other C-level management positions. This complexity is in contrast to the frequently found attitude that personnel management is exclusively a matter for the HR department, which is not involved in the company's business processes but only contributes to them. A similar development has been seen in the IT departments in recent decades: In successful companies, IT departments are no longer seen as mere suppliers to the specialist departments; instead, they are increasingly becoming the focus of corporate management, which makes the Chief Digital Officer a central management position (Dumeresque, 2014).

This close networking shows that the department's importance as such must be appreciated and that a corresponding flow of information between departments must take place. Predicting future needs is a central function of HR departments. However, this can only be done by appropriate information from the other business units. The complexity of this task in modern companies is also emphasized in the work of Stevens and Campion (1994). In particular, modern forms of work and communication, which are based intensively on cooperation in often interdisciplinary and international teams, represent a challenge here. The demands placed on

employees can no longer be captured here solely by their knowledge in the form of a short tender text but must take into account the complex interaction of the individual, departments and processes. This requires the HR department to have a deep understanding of the company and team processes that are affected and thus to be well integrated into them. This allows requirements, which arise, for example, from digitalization or globalization and internationalization, to be better met. The requirements of internationalisation are considered a central task for HR policy by Jabbour and Santos (2008), for example. At the same time, the authors also point out that while the creation of an inclusive HR policy must be one of the objectives of sustainable HR departments, this can only be successful if it is anchored in the corporate strategy and culture itself. In this case, too, the authors show that a close alignment of corporate culture and HR departments' goals can have a profound influence on their success.

The similarities between leadership and HR-Management become more clear with a gaze towards what Ulrich (1998) describes as HR as an agent of change. The importance of HR policy for internal company changes, which Meyer-Ferreira and Lombriser (2003) emphasized, is clearly demonstrated by company mergers, for example. Bligh (2006), for example, deals with the effects of such mergers on the corporate culture of both companies involved and subsumes the results under the term "culture clash". Bligh explains that it is precisely this culture clash, i.e. the clash of different corporate cultures, that is often blamed for the disappointing results of company mergers. The author reports on a survey of 218 US companies, most of which agreed that corporate culture is one of the key success predictors of mergers and acquisitions. These include corporate identity, communication difficulties, human resource problems or differences between groups. This is also emphasized by Marks and Mirvis (2011), for example: "Most managers place too little emphasis or even largely ignore the management of corporate culture and HR issues in connection with mergers and acquisitions. This leads to conflicts between management teams, stereotyping, problems with the integration of new IT systems or structures and finally to financial failures."

Bligh (2006) further reports that mergers can be traumatic for employees and managers, which can lead to lower commitment, trust and thus lower productivity. In particular, employee satisfaction could be damaged in the long term by mergers. As a consequence, this can lead to higher turnover, a greater chance of absences and lower productivity in the company. The author describes this as one of the main reasons for the often unsatisfactory mergers and acquisitions results.

Ivancevich, Schweiger and Power (1987) also identify this as one of the main problems of M&A. In particular, the authors focus on the uncertainty about the personnel consequences of M&A: "Will I have a job? Will I be transferred? Will I be demoted? What will happen to my benefits?" (S. 19). Ivancevich et al (1987) argue that in the planning of mergers, legal and economic aspects are primarily discussed by management, while the effects on the employees themselves are less frequently considered. In particular, such mergers' psychological and possibly traumatic consequences are usually left out of the equation. In response, the researchers argue that the HR function must urgently be integrated into planning to prevent these problems - a point also emphasized by Meyer-Ferreira and Eberhardt (2006): HR management has a special role in mergers, which can help decide on their success, but is not always taken into account by management.

That the importance of HR in change processes is not only evident in the context of mergers and similar financial transactions is demonstrated by the work of Conway and Monks (2007). In an empirical study, the authors examined the influence of different HR practices on healthcare workers' commitment to change. In this study, employees were asked to identify from a list of change processes that were taking place one that affected them at the time of the survey and on which they had a personal opinion. Their attitude towards this change process was then surveyed to measure commitment. Employees were then also given a questionnaire to assess their satisfaction with HR and management practices and a number of other employer-oriented assessments. The results showed that there is a discrepancy between the HR practices valued by employees (reward programs, communication and work-life balance programs) and those that are increasingly discussed in the

management context (conditional reward systems, performance management or development programs). At the same time, however, Conway and Monks (2007) note that HR practices and the management style in the company have had a significant influence on satisfaction with and perception of the change processes.

Caldwell (2001) contrasts this importance of the implementation of HR departments in change processes with observations from practice: For a long time, HR representatives in innovation and change processes could only take on the roles of conformist or deviant - i.e., they could either only participate in a supporting and advisory capacity through their own experience or be actively and independently involved as a deviant. Research findings

2.2 Personality & Values

Research on different aspects of personality – as it will be discussed within this section of the thesis – can focus both on employees' personalities and those of leaders themselves. While the typical focus seems to lie on the employee personality (see section 2.2.1), it still seems noteworthy that leadership personality is a crucial aspect. Similarly, personality can also be a relevant issue for managers themselves. Personality, as described by Sosnowska et al. (2019), for example, as a stable set of characteristics that is suitable for describing individuals and their interindividual differences, also affects the activities and perceptions of managers. In this context, it can be stated that a manager's personality has a decisive influence on both his or her actions and his or her personality. In general, it can even be assumed that the decision to be a leader depends to a large extent on one's own personality. In this context, it is assumed, for example, that extraverted persons should tend to want to take on a leadership role. This self-perception of leaders is also empirically examined by Bergner, Kanape and Rybnicek (2019), for example: Accordingly, leadership success is not only a result but also a predictor: Based on an empirical study, the authors conclude that leadership success influences one's own leadership perception. Successful leaders - who also receive positive feedback from their employees

and superiors - also tend to be significantly more interested in their own leadership activities. This shows the high complexity of the topic: On the one hand - as the introductory presentation in this section showed - a person's personality and interests influence their leadership behaviour and successively their leadership success. This, on the other hand, has an effect on interest and motivation.

Personality Models

As Neubauer (2018) points out, there are countless studies regarding the predictive power of personality, some of which are summarized in meta-analyses. One of the most prominent applications of the Big Five is the prediction of professional performance. Personality is directly related to professional success (Hurtz & Donovan, 2000). This is also understood as a measure of construct validity, especially since older research results based on other models of personality have been unable to make satisfactory predictions (Hurtz & Donovan, 2000).

The universal deduction from these studies was that personality tests, as they are common within psychology, did not show sufficient predictive validity to qualify their use in personnel selection. Indeed, psychological studies that did not (yet) focus on the Big Five framework found that personality tests were among the least valid types of personnel selection tests. For example, they showed an average weighted correlation of 0.21 for predicting work performance, resulting in personality tests having a low validity (Hurtz & Donovan, 2000).

On the other hand, more modern studies show significantly more positive results regarding the predictive validity of the personality, as a much-acclaimed study by Barrick and Mount (1991) has shown. According to this study, personality is able to at least partially predict different measures of professional success (for example, the speed of learning new skills, assessments by superiors or sales success). A more recent meta-study by Barrick, Mount and Judge (2001) also confirmed the importance of the Big Five as predictors of various aspects of professional success. In this respect, the authors used different success criteria (success in teamwork,

manager assessments, training performance, etc.) to show the importance of the Big Five dimensions for different occupational groups. Barrick, Mount and Judge (2001) therefore analysed the Big Five variables' predictive validity on five different jobs: sales people, managers, professionals, policemen, and workers. One of their clearest results regards conscientiousness, which was able to predict job performance for all five of these jobs. Extraversion, however, also proved to be a strong predictor of overall job performance for sales people, managers and policemen, whereas the other three Big Five variables showed less clear results.

Judge and Ilies (2002) describe that a number of challenges characterizes research into the relationship between (performance) motivation and personality. One of the central challenges is that for both constructs, there are many different theories, models, and measurement approaches, which makes it difficult to interpret found relationships and thus leaves an often unclear picture. Since both motivation and personality can be defined in such different ways, contradictory results often emerge with regard to the interplay, according to Judge and Ilies (2002). The authors tried to address this problem themselves in an overview paper, for which they concentrated on the construct of performance motivation on the one hand and the Big Five on the other. For this purpose, the authors analysed several hundred studies in the context of a meta-analysis and found that neuroticism, in particular, is directly related to the aspect of goal setting (as part of performance motivation). The analyses also showed that tolerance and conscientiousness are predictors of performance motivation.

Their findings thus partly contradict the typical state of research in motivational psychology, according to Judge and Ilies (2002), where dispositional variables such as personality are rarely taken into account. However, the results of Judge and Ilies (2002) clearly show - according to the authors themselves - that personality is indeed an important aspect in explaining differences in motivation: Neuroticism was negatively related to each of the theoretical perspectives on performance motivation. Similarly, conscientiousness was positively associated with all three

motivation criteria. The other big five characteristics - extraversion, openness to experience and tolerance - generally showed weaker correlations with the motivation criteria, and the direction of the correlations was sometimes inconsistent across the criteria (Judge and Ilies, 2002).

Other research results, such as those of Bempechat and Shernoff (2012), show that performance motivation also depends on one's own experience. In general, the relationship between performance and performance motivation can be a complex one. Performance motivation can influence the experiences made, for example, by leading to better performance. These better performances - as positive experiences - can, in turn, influence the extent of performance motivation. Aspects such as parental parenting behaviour in childhood (Bempechat & Shernoff, 2012; Wigfield, Eccles, Fredricks, Simkins, Roeser & Schiefele, 2015) in turn can influence this relationship. Closely related to these approaches is research on self-efficacy, i.e. the belief of individuals that they are effective and can perform well (Yusuf, 2011). The assumption in this area is that self-efficacy and performance motivation are also interrelated. Thus, people who believe that their own actions are crucial to their success are more likely to describe themselves as motivated to perform.

The personality traits that make up the dark triad are strongly associated with different forms and aspects of bullying. Machiavellianism, in particular, has been shown to directly predict bullying (van Geel, Goermans, Toprak & Vedder, 2017). These findings are supported by those of Baughman, Dearing, Giammarco and Vernon (2012), who were able to show that all aspects of the dark triad are relevant for predicting bullying not only in the workplace but also in general settings.

Personalities that possess traits of the dark triad form the basis for what is referred to as "dark leadership" (Furtner, Maran & Rauthmann, 2017). On the one hand, these personality traits are considered crucial for an organization's success,

as they are strongly associated with the profile of a strong leader. On the other hand, in the long run, they are often associated with destructive leadership styles, as they usually manifest themselves after reaching a leadership position (Externbrink & Keil, 2018).

Narcissism as a personality trait can be described as a tendency to overestimate oneself, to consider oneself particularly attractive, successful and intelligent (Campbell, Hoffman, Campbell & Marchisio, 2011). Existing research on narcissism identifies two types: grandiose and vulnerable narcissism. While grandiose narcissism is characterised by a tendency towards exhibitionism, lack of modesty and interpersonal dominance, the vulnerable type is most often associated with a need for attention and recognition, negative affect, mistrust and selfishness (Miller et al., 2012). While research on the vulnerable type of narcissism is mainly conducted within clinical research, grandiose narcissism is much more commonly associated with the dark triad (Maples, Lamkin & Miller, 2014). It is argued that high levels of narcissism are directly linked to various aspects of aggression - particularly in response to threats to one's self-worth. Baughman et al. (2012) argue that narcissists mostly tend to use aggressive and bullying behaviour in response to potential threats, usually resorting to instrumental aggression.

Machiavellianism's main idea can be described as the "ends justify the means" approach or that immoral actions can and should be used when necessary to achieve a common good. For Machiavellians, moral integrity serves only as a tool to improve public image and not as a core value (Externbrink & Keil, 2018). Machiavellians are deliberately deceptive and manipulative, and at the same time, they are often suspicious and cynical. They also assume from the outset that interaction partners have bad intentions and see them as objects rather than individuals. For them, informal rewards - such as appreciation or recognition - are of little importance. Therefore, they do not seek validation from others. The Machiavellian usually appears self-confident, charismatic and assured, but acts in a reserved and detached manner (Kruse, 2016). Furthermore, Machiavellians can control their emotions, know how to assess themselves and their own abilities, do not act impulsively, and are long-term

oriented (Furtner, Maran & Rauthmann, 2017). Baughman et al. (2012) describe that bullies who score particularly high on the Machiavellian trait tend to rely heavily on manipulation and social deception. Because they usually can predict others' behaviour, they tend to exhibit indirect forms of aggression such as manipulations of social situations and attitudes.

Psychopathy is considered the darkest trait of the entire dark triad. Olver, Neumann, Sewall, Lewis, Hare and Wong (2018) describe psychopaths as "social predators". They are charming, but at the same time, ruthless and manipulative. Psychopathy originated in clinical research and represents a personality disorder that combines affective, behavioural, interpersonal and antisocial traits (Kruse, 2016). Psychopaths, like Machiavellians and narcissists, put their own well-being first. In addition, the psychopath, like the other two facets of the dark triad, is characterised by emotional coldness, self-righteousness and egocentricity. The personality trait of psychopathy is characterised by low self-control, high impulsivity and disturbed affect regulation.

Research on Values

Values are defined by Schwartz (2012, p. 3) as cross-situational, largely stable qualities or characteristics of a person and are thus closely related to the concept of personality, which is widely used in psychology (see, for example, research on the so-called Big Five; Aluja & Garcia, 2004; Barrick & Mount, 1991), which also describes a set of largely stable characteristics of a person.

According to Schwartz (2012, p. 3), research on values as a central concept in the social sciences goes back to the end of the 19th century. Therefore, relevant research deals with how values can influence or predict human action and which value areas can be assumed to be relevant. A total of four areas could be identified in this regard, to which ten values can be assigned. An overview of these values and their allocation to value areas is shown in Figure 3.

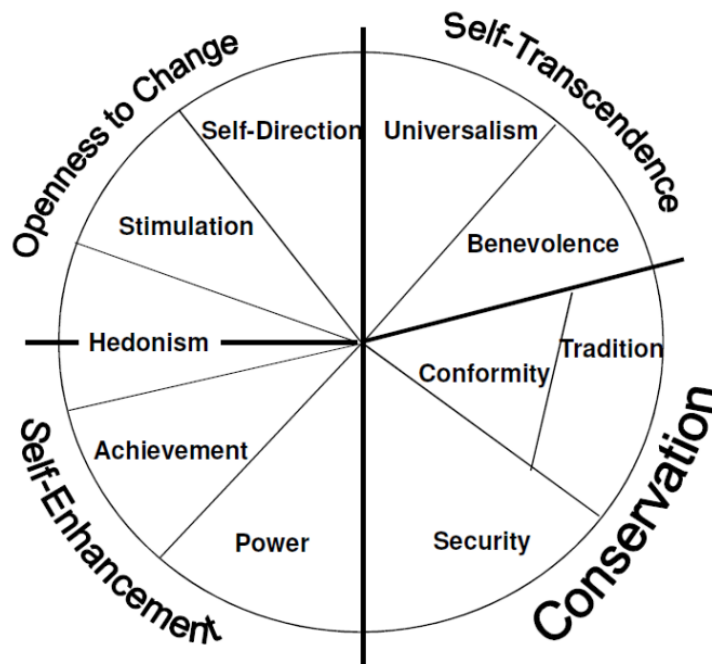


Figure 3. Human values (Schwartz, 2012)

Schwartz (2012) postulates that three universal requirements of human existence, individually or in combination, give rise to the set of 10 distinct motivational goals, also known as values: (a) basic needs of the individual or biological organism (a source of e.g. stimulation values), (b) requirements of successful interaction between people (e.g. benevolence) and (c) requirements for the survival of groups and societies (e.g. conformity). It is heard that in order to coordinate their pursuit of these goals, individuals need to express them as values. Individual differences in the importance of particular values result from the unique combination of biological endowments, social experiences and exposure to culturally specific definitions of what is desirable. People's value priorities reflect strategies adopted to cope with these universal requirements.

2.3 Employees – Commitment, Motivation

Whereas the previous sections focused either on leadership behavior or on the personality of employees, this section of the work lies the focus on the core-variable

of the thesis itself – the commitment and related variables of employees. Organizational commitment is described here from various perspectives and within different definitions, with the depiction being supplemented by an overview of the strongly related field of employee motivation.

Organisational Commitment

Becker, Billings, Eveleth and Gilbert (1996, p. 464) define organisational commitment as “the psychological attachment of workers to their workplace”. This commitment, in turn, is connected to a variety of positive outcomes for both the company/organisation and the employees themselves, as the authors further point out. Highly committed employees tend to be more satisfied with their jobs, show higher motivation and have better attendance than such with lower commitment. However, Becker et al (1996) argue further that the relationship of commitment and actual job-performance – one of the most important factors for practitioners and researchers alike – seems less clear, with various results ranging from positive to non-existing connections between those two factors. “Increasing and maintaining organizational commitment at a higher level can positively affect employees’ work behavior, not just dampen their turnover intentions.” (Cohen, 2007, p. 352)

Felfe (2008) argues that employee satisfaction is also strongly related to their loyalty to the company. A high level of employee satisfaction is thus also associated with increased loyalty to the company. As the author further describes, this loyalty is not only relevant for the company itself, but also for its employees. By sensing a feeling of belonging to the company and being bound to it, the employees' need for loyalty and recognition can also be strengthened. This, in turn, is experienced as positive by the employees.

Employee retention is also referred to as organizational commitment, Felfe and Wombacher (2016) explain. Commitment stands for the psychological bond between the individual employee and the organisation or company (Felfe & Wombacher, 2016, p. 130). However, as Felfe and Wombacher (2016) emphasise, this is

not a one-dimensional construct but rather the complex interaction of several factors. Felfe and Wombacher (2016) refer to an older work by Felfe (2008), which defines commitment as consisting of affective, calculative and normative commitment. A further distinction is that of the commitment goal. Felfe and Wombacher (2016) state that the commitment does not necessarily have to relate exclusively to the actual company but can also apply to the team or department.

Felfe and Wombacher (2016) also refer to the affective level of commitment as the emotional facet, which describes the identification with the values and principles of a company. The authors also assign the pride of feeling part of a company and a sense of belonging to it to this level of attachment. In contrast, the imputed facet is described as the counterpart of the emotional level. This facet is also described as a rationally based bond, where the main issue is the opportunity to switch to another company and the associated costs and disadvantages. The normative bond forms the third facet, according to Felfe and Wombacher (2016). It describes the social or moral responsibility towards other people - for example, colleagues or team members.

In summary, the authors state that these three facets are by no means mutually exclusive aspects of employee commitment. Rather, they can occur independently and in different forms. In the ideal case, each of the three levels is strongly pronounced.

A seminal paper by Allen and Meyer (1993) argues in this context that attachment or commitment is not a one-dimensional construct: Individuals can be committed to an organisation in different ways and have different sources of that commitment. It also points out (see Singh & Gupta, 2015) that attachment does not necessarily always and exclusively relate to the organisation as a whole: For example, a person may be attached to the leader or a team, but also to an entire organisation and its values. Meyer and Allen (1997) distinguish between three fundamentally different types of commitment - calculative, normative and emotional.

The three aspects of commitment, according to Meyer and Allen (1997), will be clarified by means of a few examples, which are primarily intended to explain the

independence of calculative, normative and emotional commitment. On the one hand, as explained above, calculative commitment is strongly dependent on working conditions, which include above all material aspects such as pay or job security. The employer and the manager create these conditions. However, the person's personality traits also seem to be relevant - according to a reference to psychology: as we have learned with reference to the model of values according to Schwartz (2012), people have different values and goals. For example, people can differ in the extent to which job security or financial security is important to them. Accordingly, even completely comparable working conditions can lead to different characteristics with regard to calculative commitment.

However, it is also worth mentioning the consideration of environmental factors, especially with regard to calculative commitment. As research results show, the labour market situation, for example, plays an important role. In summary, it can be assumed that a difficult labour market situation - i.e. one characterised by high unemployment rates - should tend to increase the imputed commitment of workers - regardless of entrepreneurial or personal variables. On the other hand, normative commitment depends primarily on a person's own attitude and the extent to which the person fundamentally believes that it is worthwhile to commit to a company. Finally, emotional commitment clearly focuses on the relationship between managers and those they manage or between companies and their employees.

Types of Employee Motivation

Empirical evidence also shows that employee motivation is a key factor that can positively influence performance: Motivated employees are more willing to perform extra (Nohria, Groysberg & Lee, 2008) and to put in a lot of effort not only to meet targets but also to exceed them. This is partly due to the concept of performance motivation:

A behaviour is considered performance-motivated if it is a concern with a standard of excellence. This definition allows a wide range of activities to be

considered performance-motivated if a person is only concerned with doing something well, better or best. The pursuit of excellence presupposes standards of excellence that can be used to evaluate performance: Whether a person compares his or her current performance with his or her own past performance ("to excel oneself"); or whether he or she compares his or her performance with the performance of other persons ("to rival or surpass others"), (...) However, we only speak of performance motivation when the drive to act comes from the person himself or herself, i.e. when he or she feels committed to a standard of proficiency and pursues performance goals, the fulfilment of which he or she strives for on his or her own initiative"(Brunstein & Heckhausen, 2006, p. 143; Translation provided by author).

According to this, behaviour is performance-motivated when a person strives to do something particularly well or better than others. According to Heckhausen (1989), an important aspect of achievement motivation is comparison, whereby this can be both a comparison with others (for example, with classmates or colleagues) and a comparison with one's own standards. The author mentions both past performance, i.e. comparison with the previous year's performance or with self-stated quality standards. According to Heckhausen (1989), it should be noted that these are self-set goals, which clearly classify performance motivation as part of intrinsic motivation.

Increasing employee motivation is one of the most important tasks that managers have to fulfil, argue Barling and Beattie (1983) or Graves, Sarkis and Zhu (2013) in a more recent research paper. Social science-based motivation research refers, among other things, to the distinction made by Ryan and Deci (2000) between intrinsic and extrinsic motivation, which are discussed as the fundamental driving forces behind human action (also outside of the leadership or corporate context). The authors explain that human action is generally based on motivation as a foundation, which is therefore described as the driving force of human action - as already indicated in relation to performance motivation (see above). The distinction between intrinsic and extrinsic aspects of motivation implies different sources of

motivation, according to Ryan and Deci (2000). Motivation, which is intrinsic, is therefore based primarily on aspects intrinsic to the person, such as a fundamental interest in an existing topic or the will to perform as well as possible. On the other hand, extrinsic motivation is more strongly characterised by the presence and effect of external motivational factors or rewards, which lead a person to perform a behaviour not because of an inner desire, but because of the desire for a corresponding reward. It is worth mentioning that although extrinsic and intrinsic motivation are fundamentally different in terms of their structure and sources, they should not be seen as extreme poles of a scale (Deci & Ryan, 2000; Ryan & Deci, 2000). Rather, they are two fundamentally different types of motivation that can vary independently of each other. Thus, scenarios with highly developed intrinsic and extrinsic motivation are just as possible as those in which only one type of motivation has a correspondingly high expression. The authors even argue in this regard that it is only in the rarest of cases that an action is actually motivated exclusively in one way; normally, there is a combination of both approaches.

Leadership behaviour can affect both intrinsic and extrinsic motivation (Barbuto, 2005). Intrinsic motivation at work occurs when employees perform activities because they find them meaningful, enjoyable or satisfying. Extrinsic motivation occurs when activities are performed to achieve a goal or to receive a reward. In this context, it should be noted that motivation in work or business is typically not purely intrinsic, but rather a partial aspect of overall motivation (Barbuto, 2005). However, the fundamental goal of transformational leadership is primarily to strengthen intrinsic motivation - Barbuto (2005) was able to show this in an empirical study. On the other hand, transactional leadership clearly aims at strengthening extrinsic motivation, as it is based on a typical reward system (Barbuto, 2005). At the same time, the author also points out that leaders can only partly create motivation: As the results of the empirical study show, the leadership approach contributes only a comparatively small part to clarifying differences in motivation.

Influence of Leadership Styles on Employees

Many leadership and (HR) management approaches seek to positively influence employees' motivation, satisfaction, performance, and commitment (Whitener, 2001). Citing various studies, Whitener (2001) accentuates the importance of employees' commitment on their job performance and states repeatedly that various corporate practices can influence this commitment. In order to foster the understanding of the mechanisms at play and the type of influence various leadership and management approaches actually have, the author conducted a cross-level analysis on a sample of $n = 1689$ employees stemming from 180 firms. The focus of the study was the interplay of human resource practices, employees' perception of organizational support, their organisational commitment and the role of trust the employees have in their management. Thus, Whitener (2001) argues for taking both personal and organisational variables into account, as both should influence the commitment and interact with each other.

In order to assess human resource practices, the author differentiates between control- and commitment-focused ones. Control-focused HR practices, Whitener (2001) explains, "aim to increase efficiency and reduce direct labor costs and rely on strict work rules and procedures and base rewards on outputs." (Whitener, 2001, p. 517). Those approaches focused on commitment instead try to generate working conditions that foster effectiveness by encouraging employees to identify themselves with the organisation and its goals. This description seems to be in accordance with Bass's (1999) description of transformational leadership (see chapter 3.1.3.1) that describes this approach also as one focusing on creating a workplace culture that focuses on employees and their satisfaction, thus creating positive relationships between the organisation and its employees.

Another variable taken into account by Whitener is the one of organisational trust. It describes the trust employees have in their organisation. Trust, however, as researchers such as Martins and Van der Berg (2013) argue, is a highly complex

construct in its own regard with typically multi-factored definitions to it. Typically, the authors explain, trust has a cognitive, an affective and a behavioural aspect, thus, being not dissimilar to various commitment models as described within section 3.3.1 of this present work. Whitener, however, defines trust for the sake of his empirical study as “employees’ beliefs about the organization’s support, commitment, and care for them” (Whitener, 2001, p. 518).

Based on these constructs, Whitener (2001) proposed multiple hypotheses that he aimed to answer based on his study's cross-level analysis. First, he assumed that employees’ perception of organisational support should be positively connected to their organisational commitment and their trust in their organisation. The commitment itself, Whitener (2001) further proposes, should also be positively connected to the trust in the organisation. Also, the influence on human resource practices on these variables and relationships are part of Whitener’s (2001) hypotheses: “Human resource practices will moderate the relationship between perceived organizational support and organizational commitment such that the relationship will be stronger under commitment human resource practices than control human resource practices” (Whitener, 2001, p. 520)

His study revealed results confirming his hypotheses – trust partially mediated the positive relationship between perceived organisational support by the employees and their commitment to the organisation. Thus, the perception of organisational support both directly and indirectly influences commitment, with the indirect influence being explained by the positive relationship of perceived support and trust on the one side and trust and commitment on the other side. In regards to the human resource practices and their influence on these relationships and factors Whitener (2001) found partially confirming results: While he was able to confirm that human resource practices (as described above) can, in fact, influence employee trust and employee commitment, only 8% and 10% of respective variance in those variables could be explained by these practices. However, the author argues that one core limitation of the study lies in assessing human resource practices, which for each of the 180 sampled firms was only assessed by one person and thus might not be a fully

representative and valid measure of the actual practices. This, the author concludes, is a potential downfall of a variety of empirical studies that aim to analyse the influence of management styles or HR practices, as these factors are complicated to assess. They are influenced by a variety of factors themselves and can only, to an unclear extent, be fully operationalized in terms of assessment.

3 Objectives and Aims of the Dissertation

3.1 Leading Research Questions

“It is axiomatic that effective leaders within organizations have committed followers.” (Jackson, Meyer & Wang, 2013). Therefore, the authors argue that it comes as no surprise that the commitment of employees is within scientific literature often discussed as one of the optimal outcomes of leadership and is therefore chosen to be the criterion of research. However, Jackson, Meyer and Wang (2013) also argue that while a large number of research articles on the connection between various types of leadership on the one hand and measures of employee commitment on the other hand exist, only comparatively little systematic work on the topic exists. This mostly stems from a wide variety of differing definitions, concepts and models – both in regards to leadership and in regards to commitment. This is among the core results that I was able to derive from the literature review reported within chapter 2 of this thesis. While it is in general understood, that leaders play an increasingly important role in shaping their organizations, still a number of questions remain unclear. I aimed to foster understanding of the complex interplay of leadership and organizational commitment. While studies such as the ones described within section 2.1 explain, that leadership behavior can positively influence organizational commitment, I identified the research gap regarding the actual nature of this influence. By explaining the social-scientific concepts of personality and values within section 2.2 I established the relevance of inter-individual differences regarding human perception and behavior. Throughout the empirical work conducted within this thesis I aim to assess, whether the relationship between leadership behavior and organizational commitment is moderated by personality and values. I argue, that these concepts strongly influence the perception of leadership behavior, as was shown within section 2.2: Depending on a person’s values and personality, the environment is perceived in different ways with according consequences for the behavior. Thus, I aim to contribute to the research gap regarding the *nature* of the relationship between leadership behavior and commitment. Also, this work therefore aims to

contribute to practitioner's work in the field, by helping leaders to understand not only how their behavior might affect employees in general, but also how the personality- and value-regarding diversity within teams can be addressed.

The present thesis seeks to analyze various leadership approaches and their influence on organizational commitment. The main research contribution lies in the extension of such research on employees' and leaders' personal values. Also, a unified model of measuring employee commitment in terms of a three-stage development process shall guide the research.

The main question that the proposed research will solve is:

- What leadership type most strongly promotes organizational commitment?
- The successive questions that the research include will address:
- Is organisational commitment a three-stage employee development process?
- What leadership style resonates with the qualities exhibited in the three developmental stages of organisational commitment?
- Are there leadership types that do not resonate with any of the characteristics in the developmental stages? What is their impact on organisational commitment then?
- Does congruence of personal values with leadership style qualities lead to a high organisational commitment?

The nature of these research question clarifies, how I plan to contribute to the existing scientific literature on the topic. Therefore, I strongly build on the existing literature and state of research, as it was described throughout chapter 2 of this thesis. The research questions derived therefrom directly address existing research gaps and are aimed to foster the understanding of the overall topic.

3.2 Proposed Contribution for Research and Practice

The concept of organizational commitment has already achieved strong recognition both within the scientific literature (see section 2.3 of this thesis) and in practitioner's work. Fostering said commitment – independent of the question, how the very nature and structure of this commitment looks like – is acknowledged by managers and leaders to be crucial for corporate success. However, as the introduction to this thesis already shows, despite the great amount of scientific literature concerned with the topic, unclarity still seems to exist both about the structure and operationalization of organizational commitment and about the predictive validity of different precursors to commitment. Therein lies the proposed contribution of the present thesis, that is concerned with these two aspects of the research gap. As the previous section shows, the present thesis aims to foster understanding of the highly complex construct and its relationships with other relevant variables from a holistic perspective. In a first step, the structure of organizational commitment is being analyzed using a strictly quantitative, data-driven approach. Following this initial assessment, further research is conducted to assess how different aspects of organizational exchange and human behavior affect organizational behavior. The main benefit of the present thesis lies in the systematic approach to assessing these variables' influence. By choosing a solely quantitative approach, the researcher is enabled with making assessments in regards to the predictive validity (see Browne, 1975) of these variables, thus comparing the strength of different precursors directly. While a wide variety of different research articles exists that is concerned with the roles of individual predictors such as leadership variables (Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014; De Vries, Bakker-Pieper & Oostenveld, 2010) or employee characteristics, the present work aims to assess the predictive validity of multiple predictors within one work, thus allowing for direct comparison of the predictive strengths of these predictors. The focus clearly lies on an approach strongly driven by the methodologies typically found within social sciences, thus using an employee-

focused method of data collection. Thus, both leadership variables and related outcomes are assessed from the employee perspective, following the notion that not only leadership intentions but rather the perceived outcomes should matter in regards to the experienced commitment of employees. This is in alignment with what Suchanek and von Brook (2017) label to be among the core challenges of contemporary leadership: As the business environment is increasingly labelled as highly complex and shaped by what Bennett and Lemoine (2014) or Codreanu (2016) describe as VUCA conditions, the intended outcomes of leadership actions and the actual outcomes only partially overlap.

As proposed by Suchanek and von Broock (2017), the ethical compass is described to be crucial for addressing the challenges within contemporary leadership in increasingly complex and ambivalent business environments. Not only does leadership in these times increase in difficulty, Suchanek and von Broock (2017) argue, but also in relevance. The business environment that the authors describe as VUCA (see Chernyak-Hai & Rabenu, 2018) requires a sound and reliable ethical framework for leaders and their economic decision making process. Bennett and Lemoine (2014) or Maier, Guillaume, Van Delden, Riddell, Haasnott and Kwakkel (2016) explain that the increasing importance and frequency of decisions is emphasised mainly by researchers who also refer to the current business environment as VUCA. The acronym, which consists of the words volatility, uncertainty, complexity and ambiguity, is an attempt to describe the common business environment. Despite the partly prevailing affinity of the present terms, according to Bennett and Lemoine (2014), a clear demarcation between them becomes apparent. Decisions are therefore in an even more central position and must also be made in an effective, fast and also adaptive manner due to the prevailing requirements of the business field (Chernyak-Hai & Rabenu, 2018).

Volatile situations often indicate an unstable or even unpredictable state, which, although not necessarily involved in further complex structures, is characterized by a lack of knowledge and a doubt about the circumstances resulting from

existing events. Volatility thus represents the general definition of VUCA often used in business economics, which includes the changes that often occur and are considered normal in modern business. Uncertainty is described as a situation characterised by a lack of knowledge, which is not described in terms of a cause-effect relationship, but is only regarded as meaningfully causal in the context of the event in question. Bennett and Lemoine (2014) emphasise that uncertainty cannot be equated with the volatility already described, i.e. an unstable situation that changes with a high probability and depends on its change in acting persons' respective attitudes. Uncertain situations thus do not seem to be volatile and also contain the potential to change in their nature (Alkhaldi et al., 2017).

According to the authors Bennett and Lemoine, the complexity of this topic, which has been emphasised in many places so far, is made clear above all by the fact that situations are characterised by a multitude of interconnected but also specific characteristics. Situations that are characterised by a doubt of the prevailing cause-effect relationships can be described as ambiguous. In this respect, ambiguous situations also pose a challenge due to their novelty: According to Bennett and Lemoine, for example, there is little historical precedent for determining events of specific causes or a factional course, as is evident in the observation of innovation processes. Millar, Groth and Mahon (2018) describe this as an exemplary VUCA situation due to the influence of all the dimensions mentioned. The aspect of ambiguity, in particular, seems to stand out here.

This environment – Suchanek and von Broock (2017) conclude – presents according challenges for contemporary leaders who are concerned with fostering ethical and morally sound behavior within their firm. The ethical compass – as it is critically discussed by the authors – provides a framework to support in the VUCA environment, as it implies that leaders are not only tasked with having to take responsibility for their own actions and their directly intended consequences, but also for their *side effects*. This is identified by the authors as one of the core challenges of (intended) ethical behavior in the VUCA environment: Apart from the main intentions of an action, a multitude of side effects has to be considered.

3.3 General Approach and Project Planning

The initial plan was to develop three empirical papers addressing the research questions. The conclusion of those three papers combined with a comprehensive literature review and additional analyses of the empirical findings will form the dissertation.

Thus, the three papers will be planned to form a coherent storyline, answering the main research question and allowing for triangulation of the data (Wilson, 2014). Table 2 displays the major milestones in the planned work.

Table 2: Relevant Milestones

Initial Literature Research & Review	November 2019 – January 2020
Development Data Collection Measures Paper 1 & 2	January & February 2020
Data Collection Phase Paper 1 & 2	February & March 2020
Development of Paper 1 – Literature & Methodology	March 2020
Presentation Trial – Preliminary Results Paper 1	March 20th 2020
Finalization Paper 1	April 2020
Exam Board – Paper 1	June 05 th 2020
Development of Paper 2	May – July 2020
Finalization Paper 2	July 2020
Presentation Paper 2 - Conference	November 2020
Literature Research for Paper 3	August 2020 – November 2020
Development Data Collection Measures Paper 3	December 2020
Data Collection Phase Paper 3	January 2021 – February 2021
Development of Paper 3	February 2021 – March 2021
Presentation Trial – Preliminary Paper 3	March 2021
Finalization Paper 3	April 2021

Exam Board 2	June 2021
Doctoral State Exam / Defence	July 2021 / TBD

One of the first steps is the conduction of an initial literature research and review. Happening in the timeframe between November 2019 until end of January 2020, relevant factors and aspects in regards to leadership, employee motivation and commitment and organizational and personal factors influencing both are identified. This builds the foundation for the work on the data collection methods that will be used for empirical papers 1 and 2. Both papers will be handled in the form of journal articles that should be published in peer-reviewed, scientific journals (see chapters 2.1, 2.2, and 2.3 of this work).

These measures will be prepared in alignment with the research questions for the separate papers and the thesis's main research questions in mind. Actual data collection will happen in February and March 2020. While the data collection is conducted, the researcher will work on the development of the first paper. This includes an initial write-up of the relevant literature review and the methodology for the first paper in alignment with the (yet to be chosen) journal for which publication is aiming for. As soon as the data is collected, initial analyses will be conducted with the goal to present a first draft of paper 1 on March 23rd 2020, at the presentation trial.

Following this presentation and the subsequent feedback on the paper, the month of April 2020 will be used to finalize the paper, so that the finalised and submitted paper can be discussed in front of the exam board on June 5th 2020.

The timeframe from May 2020 to July 2020 will also be used to develop the second journal article (see chapter 2.2). As data collection for both papers 1 and 2 will happen at the same time, in this timeframe, only the analyses have to be conducted and the relevant literature review for paper 2 has to be finalized. The goal is to finalize the second paper in July of 2020.

As paper 3 puts a stronger focus on personal values and preferences for leadership, additional time is planned for further literature research on these topics. The timeframe August 2020 until November 2020 will be used to develop the literature

review for the third paper, which will also form the foundation for developing the relevant methodology in December 2020. In January and February 2021, the third paper's data collection should be conducted, which allows for finalizing the third paper by the end of March 2021, where it will be presented at the presentation trial (date unknown). April 2021 will then be used to finalize the paper in accordance with the feedback received at the presentation trial.

3.4 Proposed Paper Structure

Paper 1 – Dimensions and Layers of Commitment

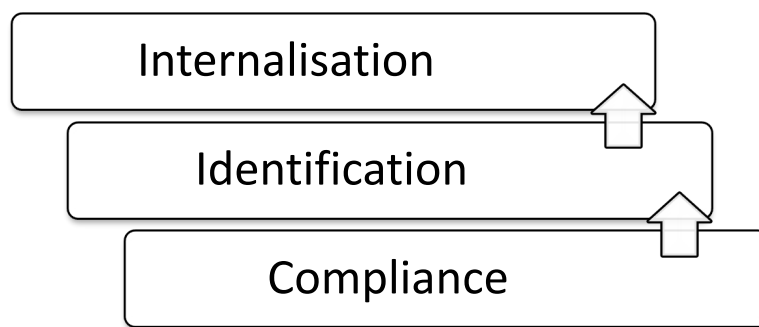


Figure 4 Tri-dimensional organisational commitment employee development model
(*Researcher presentation, as discussed in Magdalena (2014) and Kelman (1958)*)

The compliance level is associated with low-level commitment because it is based on cost-benefit analysis of the employee-organisation relationship (Nitesh, NandaKumar and Kumar, 2013). The identification stage is a result of workers allowing themselves to be influenced by and feel part of the rest of the team, and often, it is driven by a sense of obligation that is associated with normative commitment. On the other hand, the internalisation stage is intrinsically-driven, where employees find congruence in the values of the organisation and theirs, as well as how operations are managed, and so forth, all of which engender passion and a strong sense of belonging (Magdalena, 2014).

Wolf (2018) discusses four layers of commitment:

Rational Commitment Layer

Behavioural Commitment Layer

Normative Commitment Layer

Emotional Commitment Layer

While those layers are not separable from each other completely, they still measure unique aspects of employee commitment, as Wolf (2018) postulates. Commitment, the author further argues, can be towards the company, the assignment and tasks, the colleagues, and towards the leaders or superiors, with different layers being independently strongly developed for each of these *commitment directions*.

Paper 1 seeks to understand how the Tri-dimensional organisational commitment employee development model (Magdalena, 2014) and the multi-layered commitment model (Wolf, 2018) are connected. Thus, if with growing commitment according to the Tri-dimensional model, the commitment on all layers grows as well.

This will answer the research question: Is organisational commitment a three-stage employee development process? How are the stages in the process associated with the different layers of commitment?

In order to assess this, *questionnaires will be developed and derived from the scientific literature* on the topic both for *measuring commitment according to the tri-dimensional model* and for *assessing the layers of commitment* (Wolf, 2018) separately. Additional sociodemographic data will be obtained.

Participants:

Data should be collected on a sample of $n > 120$ participants.

Minimum 1-year overall work experience

No further restrictions or limitations

Paper 2 – Leadership, Personality and Commitment

What leadership style resonates with the qualities exhibited in the three developmental stages of organisational commitment?

When one speaks of leadership or leadership behavior, this usually means either the leadership of employees or the company or management. While these latter aspects of leadership are also relevant areas, the work in question focuses on leadership. Researchers like Felfe (2009) or Yukl, Gordon and Taber (2002) describe the leadership of employees as controlling their behavior in the sense of a company or organization's goals. The methods of this control are, for example, supporting, delegating activities or instructing.

Neubauer, Bergner and Felfe (2012) describe the performance of employees as determinants of leadership success. The authors explain that this depends on three major factors: The ability to act describes the sum of the knowledge and abilities of the acting actors - the authors describe not only their technical competences but also interdisciplinary competencies such as assertiveness or communication skills. These aspects can be influenced, for example, by appropriate feedback or training. The second factor is employees' motivation, whether they really want to use their skills and competences. This area can also be achieved by the manager through appropriate communication such as the clear agreement of goals or the setting of appropriate incentives. Finally, according to Neubauer, Bergner and Felfe (2012), the room for maneuver of the employees is the third aspect that influences employee performance: If employees have the opportunity to work independently, they would also use it. The superiors must create the necessary freedom for this by appropriate structures or by the delegation of not only actions but also decisions.

Implementing new visions and motivating employees to share these visions is understood as a new core task of leadership. A much-cited article by Bass (1999) also addresses this transformational leadership. Bass describes how it is possible for business leaders to reunite the organization's goals and values with those of its members or stakeholders as a key prerequisite for the transformational leader. Such

a leader is described here as motivating and inspiring and needs a high degree of character and emotional development to be able to fulfill their tasks. At the same time, Bass (1999) also later describes that transformational leadership seems to better respond to the modern business world's challenges than older leadership approaches, such as the highly instructive transactional leadership style.

The appropriateness of leadership styles can influence employee satisfaction and commitment.

For paper 2 the following research question shall be answered:

What leadership style resonates with the qualities exhibited in the three developmental stages of organisational commitment?

The perceived leadership style, the perceived quality of leadership communication, employee personality and commitment shall be measured.

Measures will be: *Multifactor Leadership Questionnaire* (MLQ; Avolio & Bass, 2004); *Perceived Leadership Communication Questionnaire* (PCLQ; Schneider, Maier, Lovrekovic & Retzbach, 2015); *Big Five Inventory* (Rammstedt & John, 2007)

Measure for assessing commitment (see paper 1)

Participants:

Data should be collected on a sample of $n > 120$ participants.

Minimum 1-year overall work experience

No further restrictions or limitations

Paper 3 – Personal Values and preferred leadership style

One of the core ideas of transformational leadership is the establishment of a connection between the employees' personal values and those of the company. Paper 3, therefore, takes a closer look at this connection and considers personal values, vocational interests, personality and preferred and perceived leadership styles.

To study values, we adopt the value theory developed by Schwartz (2012). It defines values as desirable, trans-situational goals that vary in their importance as guiding principles in people's lives (Roccas, Sagiy, Schwartz & Knafo, 2002). The theoretical model proposes 10 motivational types of values (see Figure 5)

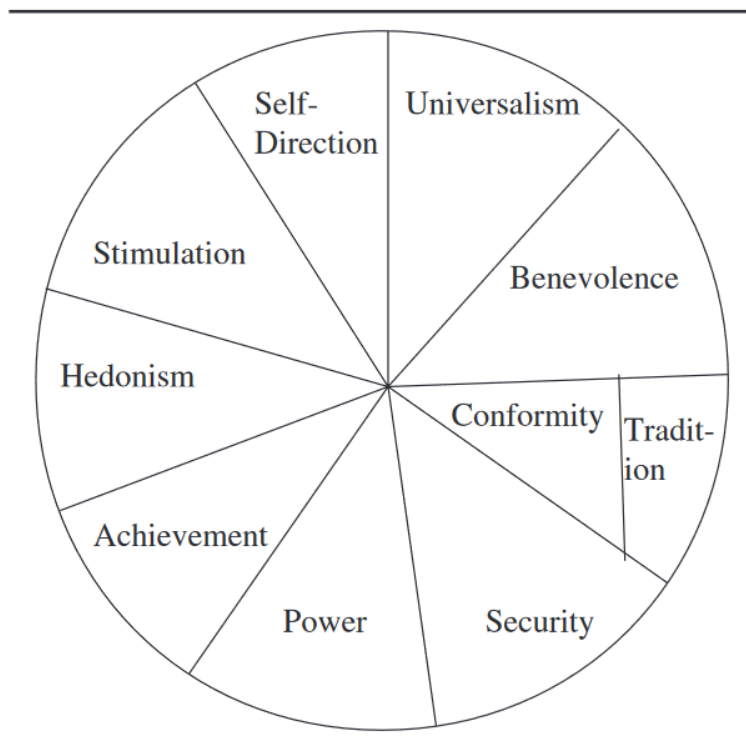


Figure 5, Motivational types of values (Roccas, Sagiy, Schwartz & Knafo, 2002, p. 791)

It is further known that there exists a relationship between values and personality, as measured by the Big Five of Personality. Given that managers' leadership influences corporate culture and corporate communication, the research question leading the development of paper 3 is: Does congruence of personal values with leadership style qualities lead to a high organisational commitment?

In order to answer this research question, an empirical study needs to be conducted once again. Relevant measures will be – again – the Big Five Questionnaire (Rammstedt & John, 2007); a measurement of personal values (Roccas, Sagiy,

Schwartz & Knafo, 2002), of perceived and preferred leadership style (MLQ; Avolio & Bass, 2004)

Participants:

Data should be collected on a sample of $n > 160$ participants.

Minimum 3-year overall work experience

No further restrictions or limitations

This initial paper structure – as described throughout this section of the thesis – was chosen in order to address the research question presented above. The main idea behind this structure was, in a first step to establish the optimal factor structure of a measurement tool for organizational commitment. Throughout the existing literature – as described within the second chapter of this thesis – I identified the most crucial research gap for this thesis: While many authors discuss and describe ways to foster organizational commitment, the conceptualizations of the very construct itself differ strongly, with accordingly differing approaches towards measuring it. This was addressed within Paper 1 (see section 5 of this thesis) and subsequently was used to address the further research problems.

The second and the third paper – as was the initial plan described here – aimed to show a comprehensive set of predictors. While individual research contributions exist, that link personality, or values, or leadership approaches respectively to organizational commitment, the present work aimed to contribute to the state of research by combining these different set of predictors in comprehensive studies.

4 Methods and Empirical Approach

4.1 General Approach

The present study follows an empirical approach with a clear focus on quantitative work. Empirical work was conducted over the course of three publications, that were developed over the course of this thesis. The quantitative approach chosen aimed to provide deep insight into the complex relationship of leadership behavior and employee-related outcomes throughout employees' lens. One of the empirical work's leading foundations was the proposed research methodology, as discussed by Döring and Bortz (2016), who explain how to outline and structure empirical work. Furthermore, regards were given to the study on organizational leadership and commitment conducted by Whitener (2001).

Whitener (2001, p. 532) concludes that one of the limitations of his own study on the influence of management practices on organisational commitment lies in assessing these practices. For the sake of his study, he measured them by taking the assessment of one person per company who was tasked to categorize the practices.

For the sake of the studies compromising this thesis, however, a different approach was chosen. As management practices are difficult to assess and would require in-depth analyses of the companies involved, insight into the organisational processes, procedures and culture and interviews with leaders. As this is deemed not practicable for the present work, a different approach is chosen. Instead of focusing on actual management and leadership practices within companies, the focus is put on employees and their perception of said management practices. By applying measures such as the MLQ (Tejeda, Scandura & Pillai, 2001; Bass & Avolio, 1996) or the PLCQ (Schneider, Maier, Lovekovic & Retzbach, 2015) leadership styles and approaches are measured on a subjective level. This poses the advantage that a more valid and reliable measurement can be achieved that does not depend only on single-person assessments based on artificial criteria (as Whitener, 2001, explains) but on employee perceptions. This also allows for easier sampling across companies, as for each employee, the appropriate assessment of leadership is available. Thus, data

stemming from employees from different companies (or, for that matter, different departments within companies) can easier be congregated. This also combats the challenge that with another approach, leadership assessment would require to put a stronger focus on employee sampling, as not even corporate-wide assessments of leadership styles might be enough. As leadership style is not (only) influenced or decided on a top-management level but also by each line manager or immediate supervisor, sampling would be more complex and limited with other approaches.

When selecting the procedure and the measuring instruments, the researcher opens up a multitude of possibilities. As Sekeran and Bougie (2016) or Bortz and Döring (2007) further describe, these should not be set up for their own sake or on the basis of their inherent advantages or disadvantages, but in relation to answering the hypotheses presented. The methodology experts emphasize that although each methodological approach offers its own advantages or disadvantages, these different approaches are not fundamentally different from one another and are fundamentally superior or inferior. Rather, some approaches are more suited to answering certain questions than others. Figure 6 shows the basic classification of research design options.

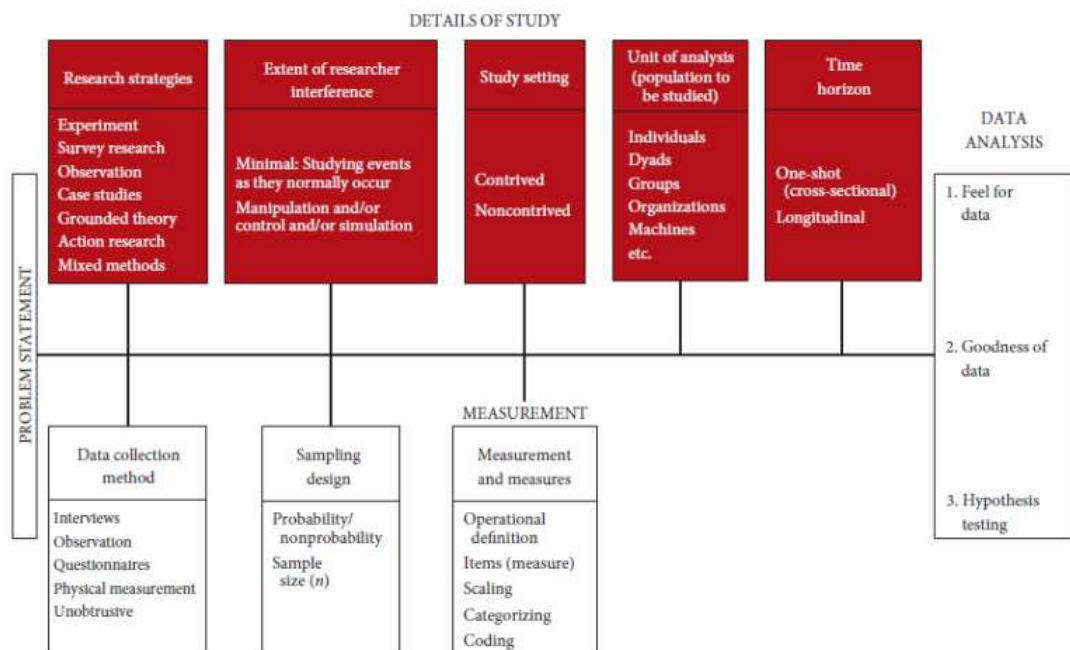


Figure 6. Research Approaches (Sekaran & Bougie, 2016, p. 122)

In a first step, the basic research strategy should therefore be defined - options such as experimental designs or (behavioral) observations are available as well as more complex approaches, such as that of mixed methods (see below), which combines different approaches to address highly complex questions to encounter.

Another differentiation option is the extent to which the researcher intervenes in the investigation - a high degree of intervention is required for experimental designs since the conditions are created artificially by the researcher. For the present work, an attempt was made here to make only minimal interventions: What is interesting here is the naturally occurring behavior or practices in the business context with regard to the management of employees. The aim is not to create artificial scenarios through manipulation or experimental variations but rather to research how management practices in Germany relate to leadership and leadership styles.

For the present study, an observational method is chosen that focuses on naturally occurring conditions and behaviors. The set of studies conducted over this

thesis follows a quantitative, empirical approach utilizing standardized questionnaires, which – partially – had to be developed (see section 3.2).

Classic methods of psychological statistics are used for the quantitative aspects. Wherever possible, priority is given to correlative methods since these normally have the highest information content. Descriptive descriptions of the collected variables form the basis on which the correlative analyzes (e.g. relationships between individual variables) are to be drawn. These methods also require a sample size of at least $n = 80$ (Cohen, 1992). The necessary analyzes and representations are carried out with Microsoft Excel (this is used in particular for initial data cleansing and preparation) and IBM SPSS.

According to Bortz and Döring (2007), the exploratory factor analysis is based on the interrelationships between the individual indicators which can be quantified as correlations (so-called correlation matrix). Only if variables are highly correlated (i.e. have common variance components) does it make any sense at all to regard them as a common to use indicators for a complex characteristic. The factor analysis now extracts from the correlation matrix a so-called factor, which is the common of the indicators in terms of content. For each variable, a so-called factor charge is calculated, which indicates how close the Relationship between the indicator variable and the latent characteristic (factor) is. These factor charges have a value range from -1 to +1 and can serve as weighting factors (Bortz & Döring, 2007).

Applying this index formation to a sample of persons, the characteristic operationalized in this way can be categorized and counted in the manner already known. If the factor analysis results in several substantial factors, this is evidence that the indicators do not cover a one-dimensional characteristic but several dimensions, which is very informative for the theory formation about the characteristic of interest. If necessary, one will then enter the complex characteristic not only with one but with several weighted indexes. The weights for these indices correspond to the indicator variables' loads on the respective factors (Bortz & Döring, 2007).

In empirical-analytical weight determination by means of factor analysis or multiple regression, inaccurate or unstable weight estimates must be expected, especially with smaller samples. Large, representative samples, which allow a so-called cross-validation of the weights, are therefore of particular advantage in this type of weight determination (Bortz & Döring, 2007).

4.2 Materials and Sample

The present thesis employed a total of three independently conducted studies, with accordingly three independent sets of materials, measures and samples. In a first step (see Meixner, 2020) the aim was to develop a unified measure of organizational commitment. The rationale behind this publication therefore was to build on the existing scientific literature and derive a valid, reliable and objective measure for assessing organizational commitment from an employee perspective. The study employed a total of $n = 300$ study participants, consisting of business professionals within Germany. Utilizing the participant pool of a German market research firm business professionals from a representative choice of business areas and positions (with a clear focus on white-collar positions) were chosen to complete a set of questionnaires derived from the state of research. In addition to the well-established Organizational Commitment Questionnaire (OCQ) by Mowday, Steers, and Porter (1979), lesser-known organizational commitment instruments such as a scale by Irefin and Mechanic (2014) were used. The data obtained from the sample described here based on the pre-existing measures was used to conduct a confirmatory factor analysis, as described within section 5 of this thesis.

The measurement framework developed within the first publication of this thesis forms, subsequently, the foundation for the second paper, which shifted its focus on predicting organizational leadership as assessed using the approach developed within Meixner (2020). This questionnaire was supplemented with both (a) a short version of the Big Five Inventory (Rammstedt & John, 2007) and (b) the Perceived Leadership Communication Questionnaire (PLCQ; Schneider, Maier, Lovrekovic & Retzbach, 2015) to capture the perceived communication quality of the leader, and

(c) the Multifactor Leadership Questionnaire (MLQ; Bass & Avolio, 1995), which participants were asked to use to assess the perceived leadership approach of their supervisors. Again, a sample of $n = 300$ business professionals from a wide variety of industries in Germany was utilized to assess the research questions of this publication. The statistical approach employed for analyzing the data can be summarized as a correlational strategy, consisting of multiple correlation analyses cumulating in a set of regression analyses.

The third study (see section 5 of this thesis) shifted the focus towards the assessment of the role of values. Following the overall structure and approach of Meixner & Pospíšil (2020), the third study added the concept of personal values (Schwartz, 2012) as potential set of moderators between organizational commitment and leadership behavior. A total of 310 recruited subjects completed Bass and Avolio's (1996) Multifactor Leadership Questionnaire (MLQ), Perceived Leadership Communication Quality (PLCQ) questionnaire, in addition to items capturing emotional and behavioral commitment; Schneider, Maier, Lovrekovic & Retzbach, 2015), a scale developed by Hayes to measure empowerment in the professional environment (Employee Empowerment Questionnaire), the self-efficacy scale of Sherer and Adams (1983), and the short version of the Big Five Inventory (BFI; Rammstedt & John, 2007) to assess the basic personality dimensions (openness to experience, conscientiousness, extraversion, agreeableness, and neuroticism).

5 Results

Throughout this thesis's development, a total of three papers empirical publications were achieved and published in international scientific journals. The overall storyline of the three papers followed the initial planning presented within chapter 1 of this thesis. In a first step, using the approach of a confirmatory factor analysis, the factor structure of organizational commitment was assessed, building on pre-existing questionnaires derived from the scientific literature. Based on this initial assessment (Meixner, 2020), the subsequent publications used the newly developed two-factor structure of organizational commitment to showcase influencing factors and the predictive validity of personality and leadership variables (Meixner, 2020b; 2021). The publications – while in their general outline planned at an initial stage – were developed subsequently, with each publication building on the previous results, thus adding to the existing knowledge in regards to the research question. The overall approach was to address the sub-questions presented throughout section 1.2 from various points of view throughout the three publications.

5.1 Paper 1 - Organizational Commitment: Re-structuring a Concept Crucial for Management and Leadership Using a Confirmatory Factor Analysis (Meixner, 2020)

Meixner's (2020) empirical study deals with the internal structure of organizational commitment and describes a construct often discussed after Steers (1977). In addition to numerous elements emphasized in industrial and organizational psychology, such as an existing organizational culture, it seems that, due to the change from a previously more work-centered to an employee-oriented labor market, it is above all commitment, often emphasized in connection with motivation. Thus employee loyalty to the company plays a crucial role in predicting job performance. Despite the high significance of the multidimensional commitment construct, which must be understood as an interplay of several complex factors, previous studies, which were based in part on different definitions of this variable or divergent

measurement approaches, could not provide consistent findings that are ubiquitous in a larger context.

An often-cited conception of the construct represents that of Wolf (2018) as a supplement to the three-dimensional model of organizational commitment, according to Allen and Meyer (1990). The author postulates, in addition to or instead of the affective, normative, and calculative forms of commitment, a rational, normative, behavioral, and emotional layer as unique, varying intensity, aspects of employee engagement, and commitment. Contrasting this model conception, Kelman (1958) and finally, Magdalena (2014) discussed the three general levels of compliance, identification, and internalization, which according to the authors, can be understood as fundamental dimensions to describe commitment. While compliance in this conception functions as the lowest stage concerning a change in behavior or also attitude, the individual can arrive at new or also changed behaviors or also attitudes as a consequence of the middle stage of change (identification) as the third stage of commitment (internalization).

The paper by Meixner (2020) attempts to review the organizational commitment models now presented concerning the construct's existing measures and examine these dimensions' relationship to each other. The investigation's basic assumption is based on Wolf (2018), who emphasizes that the existing assumptions can certainly be supplemented with other models. Overall, the model postulated by Meixner (2020) was thus reviewed, which, starting from the described levels according to Wolf (2018), should be able to achieve the three levels identified by Kelman (1958) and Magdalena (2014) (see Figure 7).

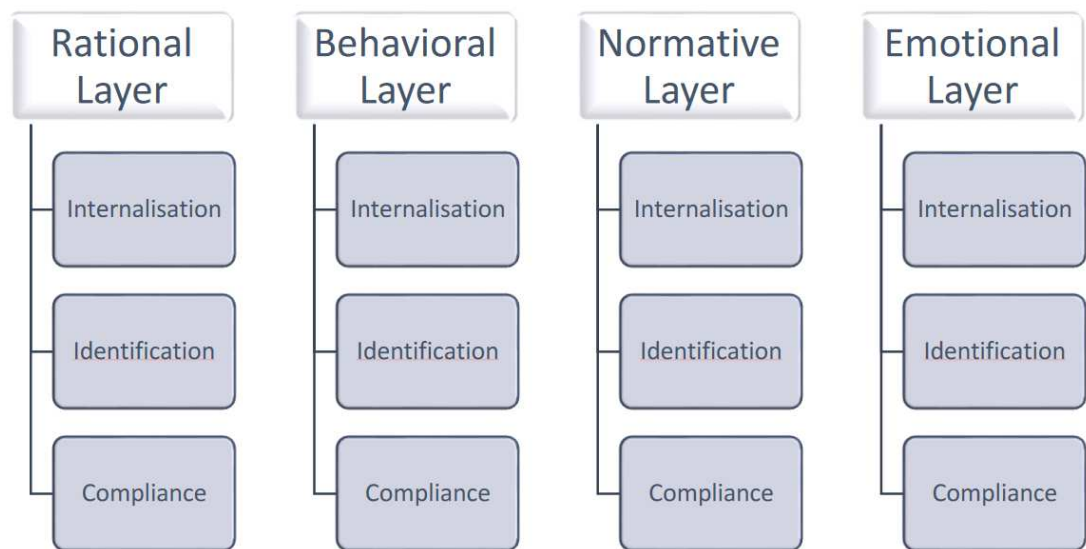


Figure 7. Proposed model of organizational commitment according to Meixner (2020, p. 79)

The total of 300 study participants, who were recruited with the help of a market research firm and had to meet the criterion of having at least five years of total professional experience (without restriction to specific areas and positions; also see Figure 8 for company sizes), completed numerous measures of organizational commitment in addition to the sociodemographic measures and those relating to their professional experience in order to create a solid data basis for the planned factor analysis.

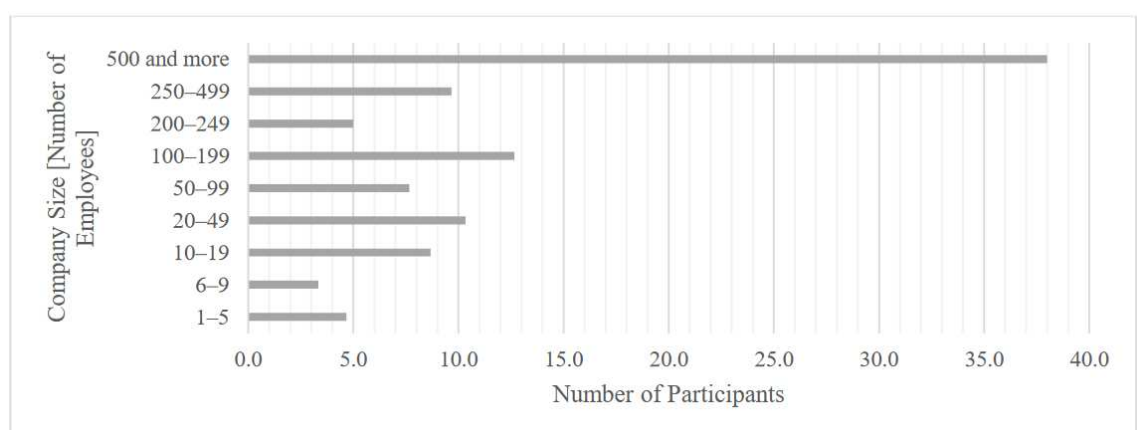


Figure 8. Company sizes of participants (Meixner, 2020, p. 83)

In addition to the well-established Organizational Commitment Questionnaire (OCQ) by Mowday, Steers, and Porter (1979), lesser-known organizational commitment instruments such as a scale by Irefin and Mechanic (2014) were used to provide an overall wide variance in definitions and aspects of the construct. Variables that seem to be related to organizational commitment only in a certain way and are captured, for example, by the Work and Well-Being Survey (UWES), also constituted a part of the test battery given online by Meixner (2020). The proposed model of organizational commitment and the proposed factor structure is depicted below:

“The items derived from the measures and presented to the participants were in accordance with the definitions provided within this work clustered into the four relevant categories: emotional, rational, normative and behavioural. This resulted in the theoretical model presented below. complete_model <- 'emot_factors =~ ACS_01 + ACS_02 + ACS_03 + ACS_04 + ACS_05 + ACS_06 + ACS_07 + ACS_08 + OCQ_05 + OCQ_06 + OCQ_08 + OCQ_10 + OCQ_12 + OCQ_13 + OCQ_14 + EC_01 + EC_02 + EC_05 + EC_13 + EC_14 rational_factors =~ CCS_01 + CCS_02 + CCS_03 + CCS_04 + CCS_05 + CCS_06 + CCS_07 + CCS_08 + OCQ_09 + OCQ_11 + OCQ_15 norm_factors =~ NCS_01 + NCS_02 + NCS_03 + NCS_04 + NCS_05 + NCS_06 + NCS_07 + NCS_08 + EC_06 + EC_10 + EC_11 + EC_12 behav_factors =~ OCQ_01 + OCQ_02 + OCQ_03 + OCQ_04 + OCQ_07 + EC_03 + EC_04 + EC_07 + EC_08 + EC_09 + EC_15 + TC_01 + TC_02 + TC_03 + TC_04 + TC_05 all_factors =~ emot_factors + rational_factors + norm_factors + behave_factors” (Meixner, 2020, p. 85).

This factor structure was introduced as the foundation for the computations. An initial analysis revealed the subsequently presented fit criteria.

Table 3. Initial depiction of fit criteria (Meixner, 2020, p. 86)*Various Fit Indices of Initial Model and Factors (Own Processing)*

	Overall	Emotional	Rational	Normative	Behavioral
Chi-Square	2916.75	531.01	116.09	166.60	330.04
Df	1171	170	44	54	104
P-value (Chi-square)	.00	.00	.00	.00	.00
Comparative Fit Index (CFI)	.72	.87	.63	.50	.66
Tucker-Lewis Index (TLI)	.70	.86	.53	.39	.61
RMSEA	.07	.08	.07	.08	.09

“As the results presented in Table 3, the initially proposed model shows a poor fit –the result of the division of the Chi-Square value by the degrees of freedom results in a value of less than 3 ($\chi^2/\text{df} = 2.49$), with both the CFI and the TLI being lower than the optimal values of CFI = .95 and TLI = .95.” (Meixner, 2020, p. 86) Subsequently, items with a poor fit were removed from the model, before re-computing the analysis (see Table 4)

Table 4. Second set of fit criteria (Meixner, 2020, p. 87)*Results of Second CFA after Elimination of Items with a Bad Fit (Own Processing)*

	Emotional	Rational	Normative	Behavioral
Chi-Square	483.52	60.65	57.59	197.20
Df	152	27	27	65
P-value (Chi-square)	.00	.00	.00	.00
Comparative Fit Index (CFI)	.88	.71	.767	.68
Tucker-Lewis Index (TLI)	.86	.61	.69	.61
RMSEA	.09	.06	.06	.08

While this did not improve the quality of all four scales, emotional and behavioral commitment showed fully satisfactory fit criteria: “While the remaining fit indices are still not perfectly satisfactory overall the emotional and the behavioural factor will be chosen for further discussion, especially in regard to the satisfactory reliability of these two scales that could be improved for both of them.” (Meixner, 2020, p. 87)

The authors' dimensions predefined concerning the model conception, which was tested using a confirmatory factor analysis combined with the reliability

analyses, showed a most appropriate model fit for both the emotional and the behavioral factors. Accordingly, the reported study emphasizes a two-factor organizational commitment model because only the factors of an emotional and behavioral-based commitment target the relationship between the employer, the company, and the employee.

The distribution of both scales developed employing this confirmatory factor analysis is in alignment with the proposed structure (see Figure 9 and 10).

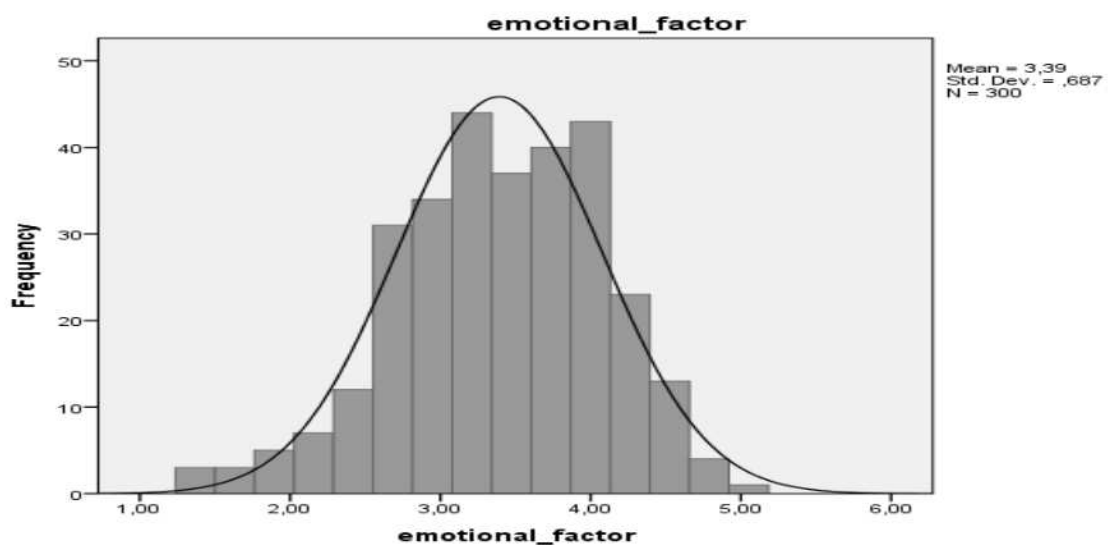


Figure 9. Emotional Commitment – distribution (Meixner, 2020, p. 88)

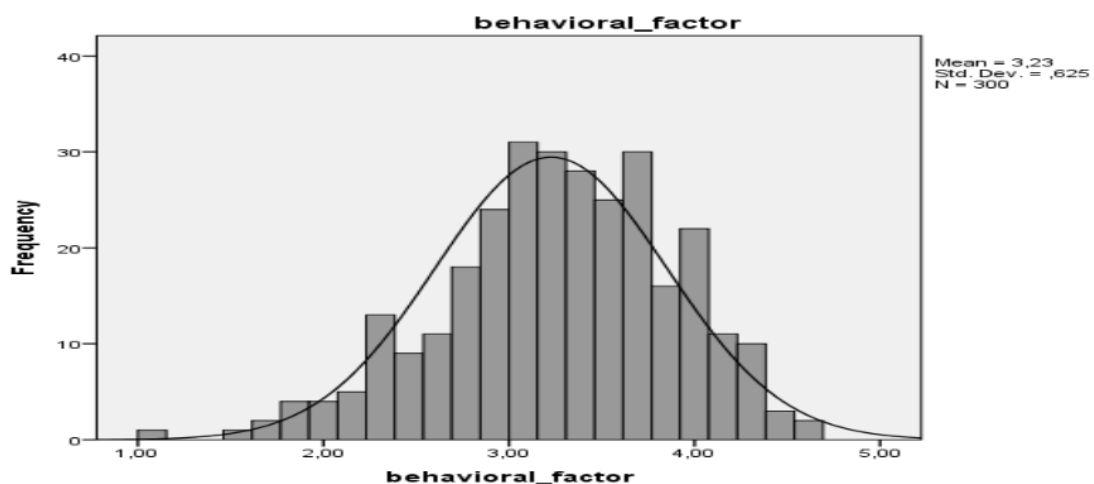


Figure 10. Behavioral Commitment – distribution (Meixner, 2020, p. 88)

Meixner (2020) argues that a possible explanation of why the factors of normative and rational commitment could not be confirmed could be found in the nature of the dimensions: thus, normative commitment seems to depend more on the personality and values of the employee. Also, rational commitment seems to be more strongly related to the general (labor) market situation, which influences the connection a person has to a company. Although not confirmed as direct influencing factors, these aspects of a person are relevant for organizational commitment and were summarized by Meixner (2020) together with the dimensions of emotional and behavioral commitment in a final model of organizational commitment (see Figure 11).

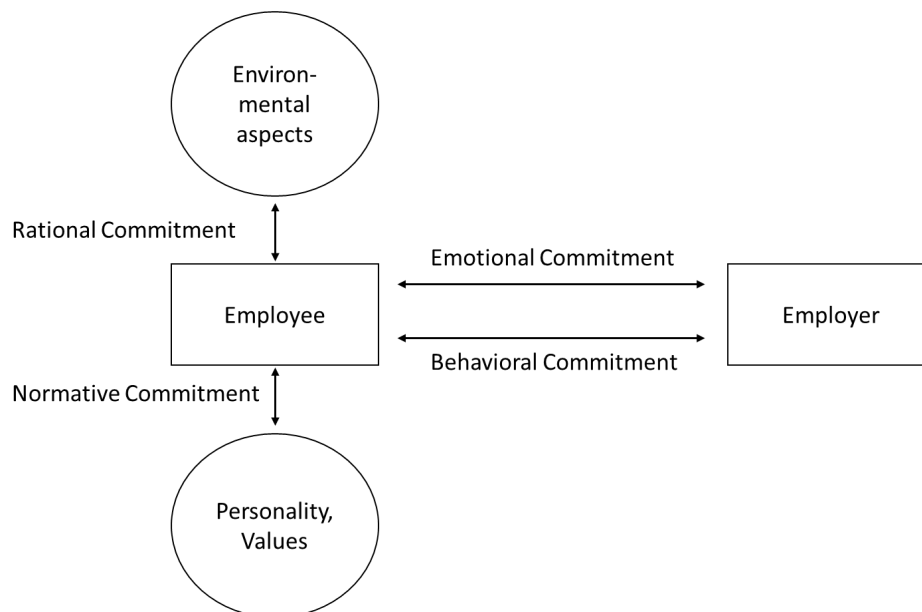


Figure 11. The final model of organizational commitment, according to Meixner (2020)

Despite the findings resulting from the systematic surveys, Meixner (2020) notes that further empirical work is still necessary to verify the proposed correlations statistically and factually. Furthermore, he also emphasizes the high importance of personal motivation, which should not be neglected in the investigations of a person's organizational commitment and, concomitantly, could also exert a non-

negligible influence on the emotional as well as behavioral aspects of the psychological construct.

An important practical implication of the findings obtained by Meixner (2020) can be implied from the identified relevance of the relationship between employer and employee: Since this can be shaped on the part of the employer, thus representing a variable that can certainly be influenced, and since previous literature has also identified, for example, positive leadership communication together with aspects of employee-oriented human resource management as relevant predictors of organizational commitment, this variable is among the aspects that must necessarily be taken into account in workplace contexts. However, it should be noted that there are also environment-specific and thus non-influenceable factors that can only be influenced to a limited extent, but which must nevertheless be taken into account when considering organizational commitment.

5.2 Paper 2 – Personality, Perceived Leadership and Commitment (Meixner, Pospíšil, 2020)

Despite the increasing influence of technological and thus also automated developments, which seem to be taking over both the economic and social environment and contributing to a strong influence on the labor market, it is, as Geyer-Klingenger et al. (2018) have already formulated, still the human workforce, according to Meixner & Pospíšil (2020), which is of fundamental necessity for entrepreneurial success and continues to gain relevance. The consequences of advancing digitization and the resulting digital transformation must, therefore, not only be seen as a threat to jobs but also as a source of jobs and profits. One crucial phenomenon in this context, which the digital process has further intensified, is the so-called war of talents (Chambers et al., 1999). This increasing struggle of companies, which relates to both the recruitment and retention of highly qualified junior staff, reaffirms employees' high value and the task of managers to maintain and promote the human resources of a company through their behavior decision-making.

Based on the existing discussions about the construct of organizational commitment and the described employee-focused human resource management, the empirical study by Meixner & Pospíšil (2020) attempts to analyze the connection between the personality traits of a company's employees, the organizational commitment of these individuals, and the perception of these concerning the behavior and communication quality of managers. Therefore, this research focuses on the aspect of employee commitment and the possibilities of the persons in managerial positions to promote the employees' motivation to reduce their intentions to quit and, consequently, increase their organizational commitment.

Previous writings focusing on the construct of organizational commitment describe a multifactorial construct, which is highly relevant in theoretical and practical contexts and seems to consist of several levels. Despite the great interest in this very topic, however, there is no known consensus on a specific model of organizational commitment. For example, Wolf (2014) postulates a construct with a four-factor structure (consisting of a rational, a normative, a behavioral, and an emotional layer), while Allen and Meyer (1990) emphasize three different types of commitment (affective, normative, behavioral), in which the affective component refers to a very emotion-based factor, the normative character refers to an individual's notion of the propriety of staying in a company. The behavioral component refers to a person's exhibited behavior.

In his empirical evaluation of the described model conceptions, Meixner (2020) emphasized only the existence of two of the postulated dimensions of organizational commitment and therefore assumed only emotional and behavioral commitment within the relationship between employees and employers. In contrast, the components of normative and rational commitment represent essential influencing factors, but, according to the author, they cannot be evaluated as independent predictors of the relationship under consideration. The study described by Meixner & Pospíšil (2020) builds on these findings and focuses on a two-factor model of the relationship between employees and managers (see Figure 12).

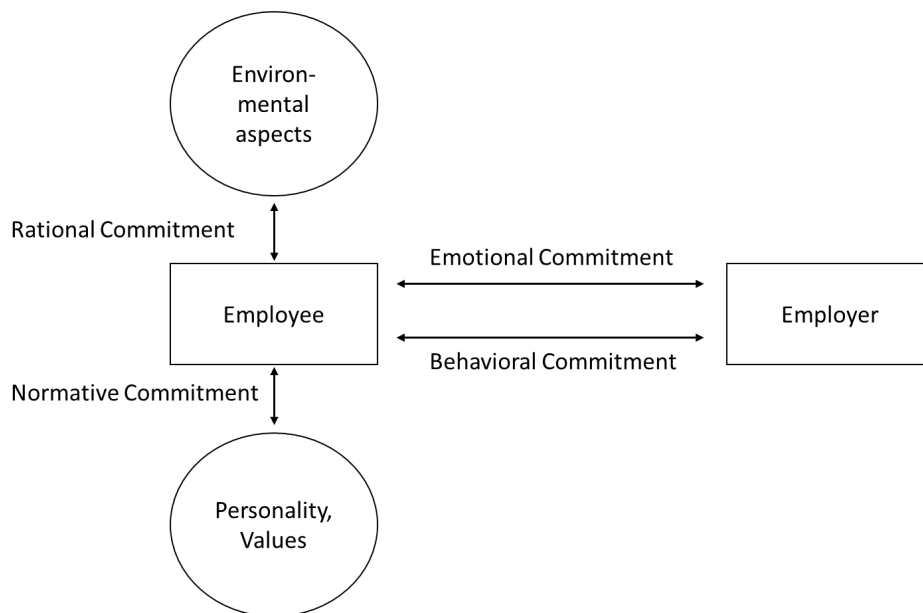


Figure 12. Model of Organizational Commitment according to Meixner (2020)

The variable of leadership behavior, which is the focus of this description, distinguishes between transformational and transactional behaviors, which are often described as two ends of a spectrum in the course of leading employees. It must be emphasized, however, that these are two different approaches that must be considered in a specific kind of independence from each other (e.g., Neubauer, Bergner, & Felfe, 2012), but certainly, pursue the common goal of improving employee motivation and commitment with the help of their different tactics. The transactional leadership style describes a specific leadership behavior characterized by precise rules, structures, and goals – the employees do what their superiors expect them to do. In contrast, transformational leadership attempts to achieve an additional increase in performance by changing the values and goals of the person being led. The emotional relationship between the manager and the employees plays a significant role. Due to the very different approaches of the leadership styles, it is clear that a different influence on commitment can be expected through these same behaviors, and thus the leadership behavior itself can be described as an essential influencing variable (Busse, 2014; Jackson, Meyer & Wang, 2013).

Employee personality is considered one of the most critical predictor variables of demonstrated behavior in corporate events (Erdheim, Wang & Zickar, 2006; Roberts, 2006; Weiss & Adler, 1984) and, consequently, influences organizational commitment (Morrison, 1997). The present study by Meixner & Pospíšil (2020) describes this variable through the concept of the Big Five and thus focuses on five main dimensions of personality (Barrick & Mount, 1991). It describes these traits as scales on which each person can be classified: Openness to Experience, Conscientiousness, Extraversion, Agreeableness, and Neuroticism. The personality traits, which can predict the behaviors shown by individuals in the future and also the motivational aspects of these, indeed show correlations with the aspects of organizational commitment postulated by Allen and Meyer (1991) concerning the study described and therefore appear to be justified for the recording of personality in the empirical investigation.

To answer the research question, Meixner & Pospíšil (2020) used both (a) a short version of the Big Five Inventory (Rammstedt & John, 2007) and (b) scales derived from previous studies (Meixner, 2020) to capture emotional and behavioral commitment, (c) the Perceived Leadership Communication Questionnaire (PLCQ; Schneider, Maier, Lovrekovic & Retzbach, 2015) to capture the perceived communication quality of the leader, and (d) the Multifactor Leadership Questionnaire (MLQ; Bass & Avolio, 1995), which participants were asked to use to assess the perceived leadership approach of their supervisors.

The results of the literature review conducted to complement the statistical analysis were able to show that both employee personality and the perceived leadership approach of supervisors can influence organizational commitment. The chosen communication within the work-related relationship between employee and leader plays a significant role in the transformational leadership approach. Shaping a positive relationship between leader and employee is a core goal of this leadership approach. A bi-variate calculation revealed meaningful correlations between personality and organizational commitment. (see Table 5).

Table 7. Regression Analyses (Meixner & Pospíšil, 2020, p. 8)

<i>Model Summary</i>									
Model	R	R Square	Adjusted R Square	Std. Error of the Estimate	Change Statistics				
					R Square Change	F Change	df1	df2	Sig. F Change
1	.286a	.082	.079	.65922	.082	26,619	1	298	.000
2	.338b	.114	.108	.64873	.032	10,718	1	297	.001
3	.584c	.341	.334	.56047	.227	101,902	1	296	.000
4	.608d	.370	.362	.54886	.029	13,659	1	295	.000
a. Predictors: (Constant), BFI_C									
b. Predictors: (Constant), BFI_C, BFI_N									
c. Predictors: (Constant), BFI_C, BFI_N, Transformational Leadership									
d. Predictors: (Constant), BFI_C, BFI_N, Transformational Leadership, PLCQ									

This is showcased both in Table 6 and Table 7, where the main results of the regression analyses conducted by Meixner and Pospíšil (2020) are described. The adjusted R^2 indicates the overall predictive power of the set of variables described within the tables, highlighting a total of $R^2 = .312$ and $R^2 = .362$ of explained variance respectively for the two sets of criteria.

It is necessary to say that only the perception of transformational leadership behavior, but not transactional or even passive-avoidant leadership behavior, seems relevant concerning predicting organizational commitment. With the perceived quality of leadership communication and a person's conscientiousness, only a transformational leadership approach can thus be identified as a significant predictor of organizational commitment. In the case of emotional commitment, the personality trait neuroticism must also be added. Concludingly, Meixner and Pospíšil (2020, p. 8) argue: "The results of both analyses show comparable, although distinctive results. Conscientiousness, transformational leadership (perceived) and leadership communication quality (perceived) are relevant predictors for both criteria, although with different impacts, as the results in both tables above show. Also, neuroticism proved to be a relevant predictor only for the emotional commitment, while it seems irrelevant for behavioral commitment. With an $R^2 = .312$ for behavioral commitment and $R^2 = .362$ for emotional commitment for both aspects of commitment meaningful predictions can be made by the set of variables chosen within the study." (Meixner & Pospíšil, 2020, p. 8)

Despite limitations of the study conducted by Meixner & Pospíšil (2020), such as the chosen correlation approach or the focus on constructs merely perceived by individuals, the empirical research work contributes to confirming the two-dimensional organizational commitment model proposed by Meixner (2020). It also indicates that both the factor of employee personality, which can be described as stable and the chosen leadership behavior aspect, which can certainly be influenced, are relevant for developing organizational commitment. These internal and external sources are essential starting points for influencing commitment, which can lead to improved organizational commitment, increased motivation, and, as a result, better performance. The findings presented here represent a first and crucial step toward furthering our understanding of the complex relationship between these factors that influence organizational commitment: “Leaders who use a transformational approach and who are able to communicate in a way that is perceived as clear, concise and positive by their employees, can improve organizational commitment and thereby lead to better engagement, strengthened motivation and better performance.” (Meixner & Pospíšil, 2020, p. 10)

5.3 Paper 3 - Moderating the relationship between leadership and commitment – an empirical study on personality and values (Meixner, Pospíšil & Zufan, 2021)

The study conducted by Meixner, Pospíšil and Zufan (2021) is dedicated to the moderating effect of personality variables and personal values in the context of the complex relationship between leadership and organizational commitment and builds on existing work on organizational commitment (Allen & Meyer, 1990; Meixner, 2020; Meixner 2020b). It emphasizes, among other things, the change in corporate structures often described in the business psychology literature, whereby it is departments such as human resources management, for example, which are becoming increasingly relevant due to the high value placed on qualified employees.

Thus, in modern corporate management and the classic corporate goals such as a targeted financial profit, the promotion of employees, and thus the promotion of organizational commitment is also the focus of many companies. Research results such as those of Macey and Schneider (2008) or also Saks (2006), which were able to prove the connection between organizational commitment and work performance in the operational context, also make the promotion of organizational commitment one of the most important tasks for managers due to this possible influence. However, Meixner (2020) was already able to show in his first publications that other aspects, such as employee personality, are also highly relevant in the context of organizational commitment. Therefore, a systematic investigation of further influencing factors, taking into account internal and personality-related variables, and including the perception of the leadership and communication approaches shown by people in managerial positions seems necessary. Organizational commitment “s a complex construct dependent both on environmental and internal aspects, thus, requiring in its prediction both variables concerning the leadership and corporate environment on the one hand and personal variables on the other hand. However, as it becomes visible with a gaze towards the relevant literature, research on the matter typically assesses only one side of this equation, therefore complicating how far these internal and external variables are connected with each other. The research gap addressed within the present paper lies in focus on leadership and personality variables.” (Meixner, Pospíšil & Zufan, 2021, p. 120)

The organizational commitment model proposed by Meixner (2020), which is also used in the study from 2021 now described, functions as the basic model of the construct and describes a two-factor construct of organizational commitment. While normative and rational aspects of commitment play a relevant role, albeit one that is not the focus of the relationship between leadership position and employee, it is the primary emotional and behavioral commitment that has been identified as the main aspects of the overall organizational construct. These aspects are now being examined for connections with both personality-related and leadership-related aspects.

In the study described above, the concept of leadership is explained primarily in terms of empowerment as a specific leadership tool. In this context, the underlying leadership approach is the transformational leadership approach, which aims to create an emotional bond between the organization and its employees. In contrast to the transactional leadership style, which is often understood as an opposite position of the transformational approach, the values of the organization are to be communicated so that these are reflected in the behavior of the employees in the sense of a value transformation even without external incentives (Stewart, 2006). Empowerment as a specific instrument of a transformational leadership approach often chosen in this context means that different methods are used to try to transfer specific areas of responsibility from the supervisor to the individual employee (Chen, Krikman, Kanfer, Allen & Rosen, 2007; Kark, Shamir & Chen, 2003). It is expected that this method can promote employee motivation, and thus a variable that is also important in the context of organizational commitment and an increased willingness to perform.

Concerning the role of personality, which is also a fundamental factor of the present study, Meixner, Pospíšil and Zufan (2021) refers to the findings of the personality researcher Goldberg (1990), who postulates both in general and in the operational context that interindividual differences lead to significant effects and thus also differences in people's behavior. In this context, Stahl (2013) postulates specific values as important distinguishing or descriptive characteristics between individuals, which can be divided into four essential value areas according to Schwartz (2012), for example (see Figure 13).

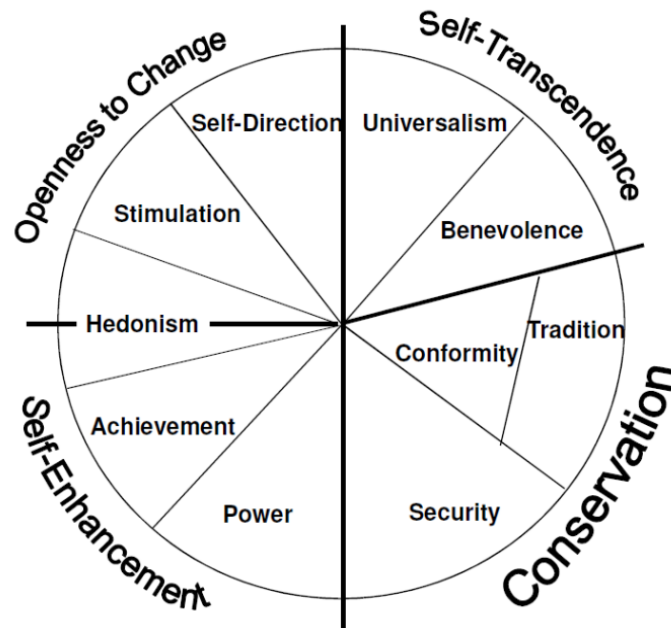


Figure 13. *Essential value areas, according to Schwartz (2012)*

These must be taken into account, especially in organizational psychology and the aspects described in the considerations of organizational commitment on the part of the manager and require a corresponding response from those in managerial positions. According to Schwartz (2012), the four value clusters, openness to change, self-transcendence, preservation, and self-improvement, can reveal both a person's personal and professional values.

An empirical study was conducted by the authors, utilizing a sample of a total of $n = 310$ business professionals from various fields (see Table 8).

Table 8. Industries and Employment Models (Meixner, Pospíšil & Zufan, 2021, p. 121)*Industries and Employment Models within the Sample*

Industry	Frequency	Percent
Agriculture, Forestry, Fishery	2	.6
Mining and Quarrying	1	.3
Manufacturing	22	7.1
Energy Supply/ Electricity, Gas, Steam and Air Conditioning	5	1.6
Construction	8	2.6
Wholesale and Retail Trade	18	5.8
Transportation and storage	22	7.1
Accommodation and Food Services	3	1.0
Information and Communication	29	9.4
Financial and Insurance Services	44	14.2
Real Estate Services	1	.3
Freelance Professional, Scientific and Technical Services	6	1.9
Administrative and Support Services	20	6.5
Public Administration and Defence	16	5.2
Education	27	8.7
Social Work	19	6.1
Human Health Services	23	7.4
Arts, Culture and Entertainment	5	1.6
Recreation/ Sports Services	1	.3
Other	38	12.3
Total	310	100.0
Employment Status		
Full-Time Employment	238	76.8
Regular Part-Time Employment	67	21.6
Self-Employed but working in another company (e.g., client co	5	1.6
Total	310	100.0

The non-experimental, correlational design of the study conducted by Meixner, Pospíšil and Zufan (2021) focuses – as already described in the introduction – primarily on the aspects of emotional and behavioral commitment postulated earlier by Meixner (2020) as fundamental factors of the concept of commitment in the operational context. As possible predictors, aspects of the (leadership) environment and those on a personal level are included, creating a combination of previous approaches with research often based on only one of these factors. A total of 310 recruited subjects completed Bass and Avolio's (1996) Multifactor Leadership Questionnaire (MLQ), Perceived Leadership Communication Quality (PLCQ) questionnaire, in addition to items capturing emotional and behavioral commitment; Schneider, Maier, Lovrekovic & Retzbach, 2015), a scale developed by Hayes to measure empowerment in the professional environment (Employee Empowerment Questionnaire), the self-efficacy scale of Sherer and Adams (1983), and the short version of the Big Five Inventory (BFI; Rammstedt & John, 2007) to assess the basic personality dimensions (openness to experience, conscientiousness, extraversion, agreeableness, and neuroticism).

Before addressing the actual research questions and hypotheses forming this work, the authors computed a reliability analysis in order to guarantee the quality of the data. Utilizing the approach described by Tavakol and Dennick (2011) as feasible for quantitative data, Cronbach Alpha values were computed for all scales used within the study (see Table 9)

Table 9. Reliability of Scales (Meixner, Pospíšil & Zufan, 2021, p. 123)

Reliability Indices of Scales

		Cronbach α	No. Of Item
Aspects of Transformational Leadership	Idealized Attributes	.80	4
	Idealized Behaviors	.82	4
	Inspirational Motivation	.83	4
	Intellectual Stimulation	.80	4
Aspects of Transactional Leadership	Individual Consideration	.78	4
	Contingent Reward	.78	4
	Management by Exception (active)	.72	4
Aspects of Passive Avoidant Leadership	Management by Exception (passive)	.70	4
	Laissez-Faire	.78	4
Outcomes of Leadership	Outcomes: Extra Effort	.79	3
	Outcomes: Effectiveness	.83	4
	Outcomes: Satisfaction	.79	2
Organizational Commitment	Emotional Commitment	.92	20
	Behavioral Commitment	.87	16
Values	Power Achievement	.80	6
	Benevolence Universalism	.79	6
	Conformity Tradition	.71	6
	Self Direction Stimulus	.82	6
	Hedonism	.70	3
	Security	.70	3
	Perceived Leadership Communication	.90	6
	Empowerment	.85	14
	Self Efficacy	.87	17

As the depiction in Table 9 shows, the reliability indices for the scales used were of satisfactory nature, thus allowing the researchers to compute the according scales, with the psychometric properties of them being depicted in Table 10.

Table 10. Psychometric Qualities of Scales (Meixner, Pospíšil & Zufan, 2021, p. 124)

		Min	Max	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>
Commitment	Emotional Commitment	1.30	5.00	3.40	.68
	Behavioral Commitment	1.44	5.00	3.34	.70
Aspects of Transformational Leadersh	Idealized Attributes	1.00	5.00	3.30	.83
	Idealized Behavior	1.00	5.00	3.38	.82
	Inspirational Motivation	1.00	5.00	3.43	.85
	Intellectual Inspiration	1.00	5.00	3.31	.81
	Individual Consideration	1.00	5.00	3.31	.85
Aspects of Transactional Leadership	Contingent Reward	1.00	5.00	3.36	.76
	Management by Exception (Active)	1.00	5.00	3.04	.78
Aspects of Passive Avoidant Leadersh	Management by Exception (Passive)	1.00	5.00	2.66	.82
	Laissez Faire	1.00	5.00	2.59	.91
Leadership Outcomes	Extra Effort	1.00	5.00	3.20	.86
	Effectiveness	1.00	5.00	3.36	.83
	Satisfaction	1.00	5.00	3.41	1.02
	Overall Outcomes	1.00	5.00	3.32	.83
Leadership Styles	Transformational Leadership	1.00	5.00	3.34	.75
	Transactional Leadership	1.00	5.00	3.20	.61
	Passive Avoidant	1.00	4.75	2.62	.80
Big Five	BFI Extraversion	1.00	5.00	3.40	.76
	BFI Agreeableness	2.00	5.00	3.51	.71
	BFI Conscientiousness	1.00	5.00	3.69	.82
	BFI Neuroticism	1.00	5.00	2.50	.82
	BFI Openness	1.00	5.00	3.40	.70
Values	Power Achievement	1.00	5.00	3.32	.73
	Benevolence Universalism	1.00	5.00	3.76	.64
	Conformity Tradition	1.00	4.67	3.03	.62
	Self Direction Stimulus	1.00	5.00	3.73	.63
	Hedonism	1.00	5.00	3.87	.71
	Security	1.00	5.00	3.91	.75
	Perceived Leadership	1.00	5.00	3.51	.93
	Communication Quality				
	Empowerment	1.36	5.00	3.39	.62
	Self Efficacy	2.12	5.00	3.67	.61

This descriptive depiction of the relevant data – following the necessary pre-tests – forms the foundation for the subsequent analyses in regard to the research objectives formed for the paper: “An analysis was conducted showing the correlations between external predictors of organizational commitment and the two aspects of organizational commitment itself. External predictors of commitment as defined within this study are leadership, perceived leadership communication quality, and empowerment.” (Meixner, Pospíšil & Zufan, 2021, p. 125)

The results of these pairwise analyses on a bi-variate level are depicted in Table 11, where significant results can be found: “positive relationships (as assumed) were found between aspects of transformational leadership and both types of commitment. The same (although typically with lower effect sizes) was found for transactional leadership, which is positively related to commitment outcomes. On the

other hand, passive avoidant leadership behaviors correlate negatively with both types of organizational commitment, proving the initial assumption.” (Meixner, Pospíšil & Zufan, 2021, p. 125)

Table 11. Correlation Analyses (pairwise; Meixner, Pospíšil & Zufan, 2021, p. 125)

Pairwise Correlations between Leadership and Commitment

			Emotional Commitment	Behavioral Commitment
	Idealized Attributes	Pearson Correlation	.56**	.47**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.00	.00
	Idealized Behavior	Pearson Correlation	.57**	.48**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.00	.00
Aspects of Transformational Leadership	Inspirational Motivation	Pearson Correlation	.55**	.46**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.00	.00
	Intellectual Inspiration	Pearson Correlation	.47**	.40**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.00	.00
	Individual Consideration	Pearson Correlation	.52**	.42**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.00	.00
Aspects of Transactional Leadership	Contingent Reward	Pearson Correlation	.51**	.44**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.00	.00
	Management by Exception (Active)	Pearson Correlation	.09	-.01
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.09	.86
Aspects of Passive Avoidant Leadership	Management by Exception (Passive)	Pearson Correlation	-.26**	-.36**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.00	.00
	Laissez Faire	Pearson Correlation	-.29**	-.34**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.00	.00
Outcomes of Leadership	Extra Effort	Pearson Correlation	.50**	.42**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.00	.00
	Effectiveness	Pearson Correlation	.51**	.49**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.00	.00
Leadership Styles	Satisfaction	Pearson Correlation	.55**	.50**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.00	.00
	Transformational Leadership	Pearson Correlation	.59**	.50**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.00	.00
	Transactional Leadership	Pearson Correlation	.38**	.26**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.00	.00
	Passive Avoidant	Pearson Correlation	-.30**	-.38**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.00	.00
	Perceived Leadership Communication Quality	Pearson Correlation	.60**	.55**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.00	.00
	Empowerment	Pearson Correlation	.52**	.44**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.00	.00

**Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed).

The multivariate analyses conducted were able to show a stable relationship between the perception of the leadership approach and the types of organizational commitment identified by Meixner (2020). However, concerning a specific description of the results reported by Meixner, Pospíšil and Zufan (2021), it must be noted

that only the leadership context variables are significant predictors for emotional commitment. The results of these analyses are depicted in the subsequently displayed Tables 12 and 13:

Table 12. Regression for Emotional Commitment (Meixner, Pospíšil & Zufan, 2021, p. 126)

<i>Regression for Leadership Variables and Emotional Commitment</i>		<i>B</i>	<i>SE B</i>	<i>β</i>	<i>p</i>
Step 1	Constant	1.86	.12		<.001
	Perceived Leadership Communication Quality	0.44	.03	.60	<.001
Step 2	Constant	1.24	.16		<.001
	Perceived Leadership Communication Quality	0.32	.03	.44	<.001
	Empowerment	0.27	.05	.27	<.001
Step 3	Constant	1.72	.20		<.001
	Perceived Leadership Communication Quality	0.32	.03	.43	<.001
	Empowerment	0.27	.05	.24	<.001
	Management by Exception (Passive)	-0.13	.03	-.16	<.001
Step 4	Constant	1.63	.20		<.001
	Perceived Leadership Communication Quality	0.23	.04	.31	<.001
	Empowerment	0.22	.05	.20	<.001
	Management by Exception (Passive)	-0.13	.03	-.16	<.001
	Inspirational Motivation	0.16	.04	.20	<.001

Note. $R^2 = .36$ for Step 1; $\Delta R^2 = .05$ for Step 2; $\Delta R^2 = .02$ for Step 3; $\Delta R^2 = .00$ for Step 4; ($p < .01$).

Table 13. Regression for Behavioral Commitment (Meixner, Pospíšil & Zufan, 2021, p. 127)

<i>Regression for Leadership Variables and Behavioral Commitment</i>		<i>B</i>	<i>SE B</i>	<i>β</i>	<i>p</i>
Step 1	Constant	1.87	.13		<.001
	Perceived Leadership Communication Quality	0.42	.03	.55	<.001
Step 2	Constant	2.65	.17		<.001
	Perceived Leadership Communication Quality	0.39	.03	.51	<.001
	Management by Exception (Passive)	-0.25	.03	-.29	<.001
Step 3	Constant	2.25	.22		<.001
	Perceived Leadership Communication Quality	0.32	.04	.43	<.001
	Management by Exception (Passive)	-0.23	.03	-.27	<.001
	Empowerment	0.17	.06	.15	<.005

Note. $R^2 = .30$ for Step 1; $\Delta R^2 = .08$ for Step 2; $\Delta R^2 = .01$ for Step 3; ($p < .01$).

This analysis shows the predictive power of the individual factors, as they are also summarized in comparison within Figure 14.

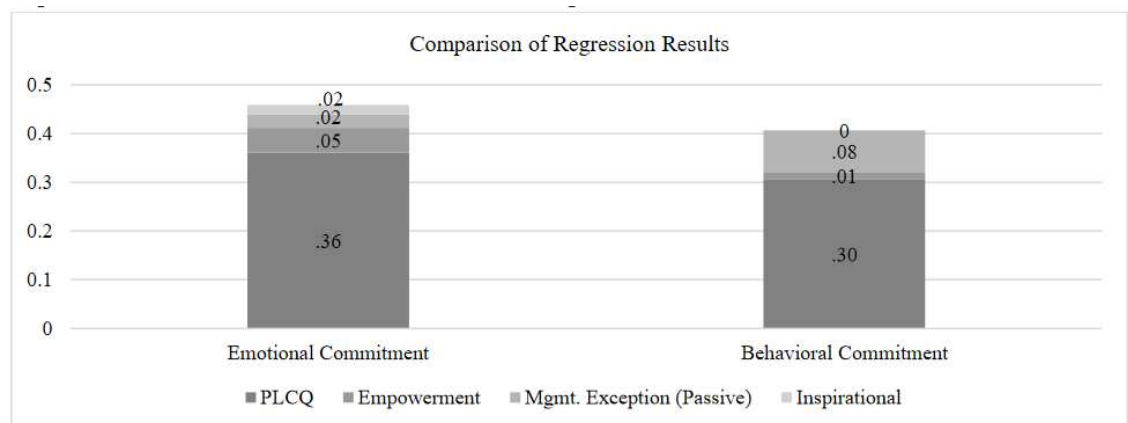


Figure 14. Comparison of Regression Analyses (Meixner, Pospíšil & Zufan, 2021, p. 127)

These preliminary results focusing on the role of leadership are supplemented by an additional set of regression analyses that also showcase the predictive validity of values, as assessed throughout this study. Figure 15 showcases the updated results obtained from this set of analyses that followed the same principle structure, while acknowledging the potential predictive power of personal values.

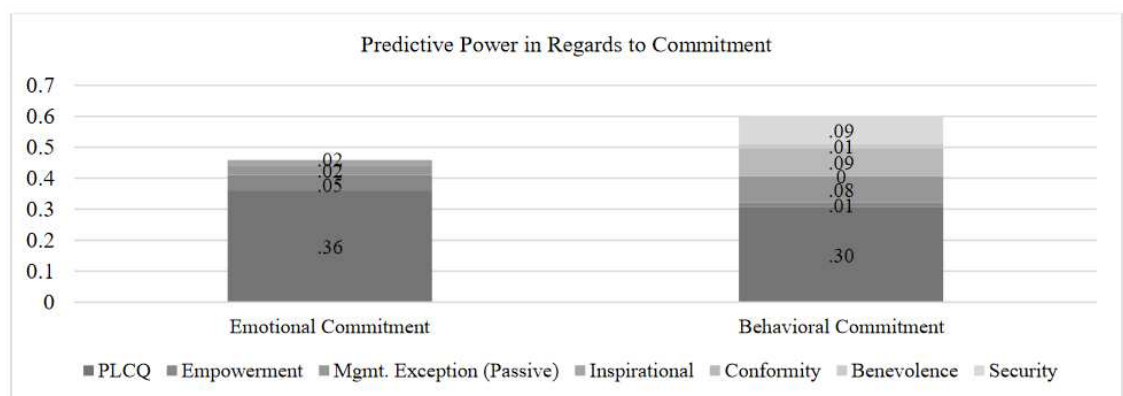


Figure 15. Comparison of Regression Analyses including Values (Meixner, Pospíšil & Zufan, 2021, p. 131)

Focusing on behavioral commitment, it is primarily the personal values highly relevant for this factor of commitment. It is primarily the values of conformity, benevolence, and security that appear to influence behavioral commitment even after

accounting for the leadership variables. Despite this prominent position of personal values, it must be emphasized that the leadership variable itself acts as the most valuable predictor of the relationships examined. It is a result that needs to be considered and analyzed in more detail, especially with a focus on practical implications: “For emotional commitment, internal predictors (personality, values, self-efficacy) cannot explain additional variance above leadership. However, for behavioral commitment, values are significant predictors, with conformity, benevolence, and security being the relevant variables.” (Meixner, Pospíšil & Zufan, 2021, p. 132)

In addition to the transformational leadership approach, which is already known as a significant predictor for numerous positive effects in the operational context, such as motivation or well-being, the role of leadership communication must also be emphasized in the findings obtained by Meixner, Pospíšil and Zufan (2021). For example, the study was able to show that the experienced empowerment of employees is also a significant, positive correlation factor in the context of strengthening organizational commitment, regardless of the leadership approach chosen. Despite the finding that the personal characteristics studied play only a minor role in predicting organizational commitment, Meixner, Pospíšil and Zufan (2021) emphatically points out that any leadership approach cannot be independent of employees' diversity and must therefore naturally be appreciated, encouraged, and also taken into account. The author also notes that this surprising result can be attributed to the fact that personality factors' diversity might already be mapped within these variables due to their high relevance in the leadership context.

Despite the crucial insights that Meixner, Pospíšil and Zufan (2021) was able to gain through his publications based on fundamental models, it must be noted that the study is limited in its geographical validity due to its sole inclusion of German companies, employers, and employees. Subsequent research needs to focus on cultural differences in order to be able to make generally valid statements or to make comparisons within different approaches. Combining samples can also be an essential addition to the existing literature due to the problems already described regarding the lack of a broad perspective (employee vs. management perspective). Finally,

experimental settings should be considered in future work: Because these tend to provide causal interpretations of the obtained results (Gill, 1982), this is an essential aspect from which future research can benefit.

5.4 Answers in Regard to the Research Question

Initiating this research project, a leading research question operationalized by a set of sub-questions was presented. These questions guided the empirical work and presented a framework against which the three publications (see chapter 3.2 of this thesis) were developed.

Over the course of the present work, contributions to the respective research questions could be derived, which will here be presented and critically discussed with regard to their contribution and aspects that remained unanswered. In a first step, the author of this thesis posed the question, whether organizational commitment is indeed – as initially proposed – a multifactorial construct, shaped on the one hand by different *directions* and different *stages*. This research question – although present throughout the work – was most strongly addressed within Meixner (2020), where the main objective of the work was to foster understanding of the actual factor structure of organizational commitment, a heavily discussed construct with varying definitions (Reichers, 1985; Cohen, 2007). This analysis's core result (see section 3.2.1; Meixner, 2020) was that a two-factor structure of organizational commitment could be revealed. Unlike other works in the field that propose a three or four factor structure (see Allen & Meyer, 1993; Cohen, 2007; Mowday, Steers & Porter, 1979), Meixner (2020) showcased that only for emotional and behavioral commitment satisfying fit indices could be observed. Despite aiming to confirm the initially assumed four factor structure and despite taking possible steps in improving the fit indices of normative and rational commitment (see Meixner, 2020; section 3.2.1), the results clearly indicated a strong fit only for emotional and behavioral commitment. Subsequently, based on the data presented in Meixner (2020), this factor structure was assessed for the subsequent empirical studies, where the validity of

the factors could be confirmed. For those two factors, Meixner (2020) identified cut-off indices that indicate the layers as proposed during the initial development based on the proposals of Wolf (2018). However, it can be summarized that the usage of such cut-offs to identify three distinct layers of commitment (for each factor of commitment respectively) might be a viable approach for practitioners, but does not seem fit to add to a scientific model: by dividing the full range with its unlimited ability to differentiate (see Döring & Bortz, 2016; Bühner, 2011) into three distinctive clusters, it leads to a loss of information to use only a layer model, especially as the quantitative data offers no indication that might imply drastically different correlation patterns over the whole range of the scales. Thus, the sub-question can be answered from two different perspectives: it is possible to deduct three distinct layers of organizational commitment based on the cut-off points derived within Meixner (2020) and thus confirm the initial proposal that three layers of commitment exist. At the same time, the results – and a gaze towards methodological literature such as Bühner (2011) – indicate that such a distinction seems to add little and might even lead to a loss of data if applied for subsequent research. Thus, it was chosen based on these results to follow the more correlational approach that omits the segmentation of data into categories and instead relies on the whole range of information (Döring & Bortz, 2016).

Thus, the proposition of the following research question was altered: When the initial question was, which leadership styles resonate with the qualities exhibited in the three developmental states of commitment, the subsequently addressed question aimed at showcasing the leadership approaches that lead to a strengthening of commitment over the whole range. This was addressed both within Meixner & Pospíšil (2020) and Meixner, Pospíšil and Zufan (2021), where the predictive validity of different leadership styles in regard to organizational commitment – as measured through the two-factor model confirmed by Meixner (2020) – was assessed. Summarizing – as depicted in section 3.2.2 and 3.2.3 – it could be shown that leadership per se seems to have a strong predictive quality in regard to commitment. Therein different approaches could be shown to be useful in fostering organizational

commitment: first, leadership communication quality (as also described throughout section 2.1) seems to be of high predictive validity: the better leadership communication is perceived, the more likely employees are to describe themselves as strongly committed, both on an emotional and a behavioral factor. Furthermore, the role of transformational leadership was confirmed throughout the publications (Meixner, 2020b; Meixner, 2021) and thus confirmed the initial assumption that transformational leadership is indeed a relevant approach to foster organizational commitment.

However, it could be shown that not only leadership but also characteristics of the employees themselves can have a predictive role when it comes to organizational commitment. Apart from the role of personality, which was confirmed within Meixner (2020b; see section 3.2.2), the present set of studies also aimed to showcase whether personal values, as they are described by Schwartz (2012) do play a moderating role in fostering understanding of organizational commitment. Meixner, Pospíšil and Zufan (2021) showed that, indeed, personal values do play a relevant role in predicting organizational commitment. However, as the multiple linear regression analysis showcased, the predictive power of the personal values is comparatively low, implying that while it does seem to contribute to the overall prediction of organizational commitment, especially in comparison to leadership variables, its predictive power is neglectable. In general, the results showcased throughout this thesis imply that while personality and values – thus, *employee variables* – do play a significant role in predicting organizational commitment, it is the segment of leadership variables that has the strongest impact. This, further, implies that certain leadership approaches seem to be positive in regards to fostering commitment independent of the person being lead. Transformational leadership and leadership focusing on its communication quality seems to be a predictor of organizational commitment independent of other variables, as the robust results throughout the empirical studies show (Meixner, 2020b; 2021).

Thus, while it seems imperative for a leader to address, acknowledge, and embrace individual employees' interindividual differences (see Ozgen, Peters, Niebuhr,

Nijkamp & Poot, 2014), transformational leadership seems to be a relevant approach regardless. Rather, the author of this thesis argues that transformational leadership, with its strong focus on interindividual differences and its positive, visionary character seems to be especially fitting to address the challenges arising from increasingly diverse and subsequently inclusive business environments.

6 Summary of Research Contribution and Discussion

6.1 Contribution of the Empirical Works

The empirical work as described within section 3.2 of this thesis and as published (Meixner, 2020; 2020b; 2021) was able to contribute to scientific debates focusing on leadership and organizational commitment. Therein lays the main contribution of the present work: In a first step, the factor structure of organizational commitment was assessed using a confirmatory factor analysis, thus a tool described by Mair (2018) or Kim, Ahtola, Spector and Mueller (1978) to be of utmost quality in assessing the structure of a complex construct. Subsequently, the predictive approaches used throughout Meixner (2020b; 2021) were able to showcase the validity of the two-factor-model of organizational commitment. Apart from their content-wise contribution in regard to the question, how various leadership and personality aspects can influence organizational commitment (see below), these results also seem strong indicators of the general construct validity. Thus, the results indicate that the model developed in Meixner (2020) seems to be of practical relevance for further work in the field.

At the same time, the results showcased the high relevance of leadership. Therein lays the second main contribution of this thesis with its focus on transformational leadership. The relevance seems especially true in regard to the challenges contemporary leaders are facing. As discussed throughout chapter 2.1.2 of this thesis, the business environment is shaped by a variety of challenges. While the selection presented there, of course, only shows some of the challenges, the implication still seems clear: with an increasingly volatile and challenging business environment, the position of leaders becomes more crucial to success. This can be argued – for example – for the topic of diversity, as it was addressed within section 2.1.2.6 of this thesis. Diversity management and subsequently, the focus on creating an inclusive work environment (Pless & Maak, 2004) is deemed to be among the core

challenges of contemporary leaders (Booyesen, 2014). This raises the question of whether different team constellations and backgrounds require different leadership and management styles or approaches. This is a factor that is argued by researchers focusing on situational leadership (Blank, Green & Weitzel, 1990; Faraci, Lock & Wheeler, 2013), who argue, that while leaders might have preferred approaches towards leadership, they should still be inclined to adjust their approach to the situation given at the moment. The present studies, however, showed that while interindividual differences contribute to explaining the relationship between leadership and organizational commitment, their role seems to be neglectable when it comes to indicating the optimal approach. Transformational leadership, Meixner, Pospíšil and Zufan (2021) showed, seems appropriate independent of value and personality differences. The author argues that this might be not despite the idea of diversity, but rather because transformational leadership, described by Walumbwa and Hartnell (2011) as employee-centric, automatically embraces interindividual differences, thus making it an appropriate approach to addressing diversity. While the results, therefore, seemingly indicate that personality differences (as one possible indicator of diversity) do not matter in regard to leadership, the opposite seems true: only the approach most likely to embrace diversity proved to be the strong predictor of organizational commitment.

In general, this thesis was introduced by the notion that both research on leadership and on organizational commitment have a long – and partially shared – history: leadership is discussed in a contemporary business environment since early studies in the 1920s (see Baumann, 2018; Landis, Hill & Harvey, 2014; Markham, 2012;) and arguably leadership debates can be traced back to ancient times (see Markham, 2012). In a similar vein, Crook (2012) and Mowday (1998) argue that research on organizational commitment became increasingly relevant as early as in the 1970s, with the precursors of this contemporary description, again, reaching back to ancient times, where the term *loyalty* was used to describe a similar relationship between servants and masters or soldiers and generals (Crook, 2012). However, the strong history of research on the two topics that shaped the present

work does not necessarily imply a lack of need for further research. As they were described as major challenges for contemporary leaders, recent developments strongly influence how and why leaders act in certain ways and how and why employees react in certain ways. This argument can – to present one clear visual – be lead in regard to generational changes and accordingly differing values over time. Authors such as Klaffke (2014) or Klein (2018) mentioned throughout section 2.1 of this thesis argue that young employees stemming from the generation of Millennials or the Generation Z differ strongly from previous generations in regard to their expectations to contemporary leadership. This implies as Bateh (2019) or Klein (2018) show, that leadership research results from earlier generations might lose their validity in the light of contemporary developments and changes, that imply a stronger desire for sensemaking and strong visions over transactional approaches (Klaffke, 2014).

6.2 Limitations and Outlook

With regard to such correlative studies, which use questionnaires with a similar structure for the survey of the predictors and indicators, the problem of the so-called common method bias (Conway & Lance, 2010) can be pointed out. This is a problem that often occurs in the social sciences, which assumes that comparable response options are always used in surveys or comparable methods of data collection. These are typically closed response options - such as Likert scales or, in the case of the present study, three-step scales - which are used for the self-assessment of people. This problem is also present in the present study, where in all sub-areas a very similar self-assessment was always used with regard to fundamentally relevant aspects of experience. Research methodologists who describe common method bias as a limitation of quantitative research (Conway & Lance, 2010, Siemsen, Roth & Oliveira, 2010) argue that the fact that such studies use very similar survey methods for all variables (which seems to make sense from another perspective, as

explained below) leads to an overestimation of the actual correlations. Because comparable methods are used, response tendencies (e.g. tendency towards positive self-representation - social desirability bias, Chung & Monroe, 2003) can lead to existing correlations appearing more pronounced.

On the other hand, however, the use of comparable survey approaches on both sides of the perspective also offers advantages, as can be argued with reference to the Brunswik symmetry approach (Kretzschmar, Spengler, Schubert, Steinmayr & Ziegler, 2018). Here, it is recommended to ensure in a prediction model that predictors and indicators are similar to each other in terms of their survey nature and structure. In concrete terms, it is emphasised that it is important to achieve a similar breadth of the survey, for example, not to use very broad scales such as the basic assessment of personality in order to predict very specific indicators of individual performance.

Another potential limitation of the present work lies in its focus on practical and pragmatic approaches towards leadership. The concept of transformational and transactional – and partially *laissez faire* – leadership is strongly discussed throughout the work and also forms the empirical foundation of the work. At the same time, an extensive review of relevant scientific literature on leadership also showcases the crucial relevance of aspects such as leaders' mindsets and leadership philosophies. To address this potential discrepancy between a more philosophical view and the pragmatic approach towards leadership chosen for the present work, Servant Leadership's concept shall be critically discussed. The author therein argues that the attitudes and worldviews described within this theoretical framework – which is described by Stahl (2013) to be one of high relevance for combatting the challenges arising for leaders in a contemporary business environment – do show parallels to the approaches chosen within this work.

The Heidelberg Model of Servant Leadership describes that there are three fundamental aspects of this leadership approach that together implement the idea of

servant leadership. Authors such as Stahl (2013) explain that the concept stems from a new worldview, which is also described as socio-centric. The three pillars of servant leadership are circular leadership, individualising leadership and balancing leadership. These three pillars, which are described accordingly by Stahl (2013), form the basis of the empirical research in the context of this thesis.

Circular leadership represents a process that sees the leader not only in a guiding, i.e. leading role but also in a role of being led. Reference can be made here not only to the concept of middle management, where managers are also embedded in a position in which they themselves are active as leading actors but at the same time also assume a role as the ones being led. On the other hand, circular leadership describes above all the interaction that takes place between the leader and the led and the interplay of roles. Therefore, leadership not only happens as a top-down approach but also as a reaction to the leaders, their challenges and requirements. This requires, as Stahl (2013) explains, a fundamental openness on the part of the leader to accept corresponding feedback and, at the same time, a corporate culture that also values feedback from the company's employees as a fundamentally valuable aspect of communication. Reference can again be made to research in the area of middle and lower management levels, where authors such as Guth and MacMillan (1986) and Hermkens and Romme (2020) explain that these are characterised by such an interplay: Such managers are normally given the task of taking on a mediating role, and thus both taking on the perspective of the employees as a relevant influencing factor and communicating their own management goals accordingly.

The second pillar describes individualising leadership, in relation to which Stahl (2013) further argues that there must be an increasing shift in the leadership context to not viewing the group of people to be led (for example, the department or the organisational unit) as a homogeneous group or even as one person, but that the fundamental diversity of these groups must be appreciated accordingly, whereby the different personalities, values, interests and personal backgrounds of the individuals to be led must be addressed. Here again, a number of parallels to

other leadership approaches emerge, which strengthen the ideas on leadership discussed by Stahl (2013) accordingly.

The third pillar of servant leadership is the balancing effect that it (optimally) exerts. Thus, servant leadership must manage to find a balance between different poles, for example, to find a balance between planning and improvising, as is also the case with agile leadership, which also seeks to take on such a mediating role (Kelly, 2012; Suscheck & Ford, 2008).

A comparison with other leadership styles, which have been mentioned repeatedly in the context of this work (for example, the concept of transformational leadership, which seems to be dominant in research), shows that these cannot necessarily be seen as a counterpoint or as mutually exclusive. For example, a consideration of the Heidelberg Model of Leadership with its three pillars and its fundamental values shows that a focus on the individual and the resulting group processes is a central aspect of servant leadership. This servant leadership, which, as Stahl (2013) explains, stems from a socio-centric worldview, thus shows clear overlaps with regard to other leadership styles or at least allows for corresponding points of contact. According to Schnorrenberg (2007), servant leadership seems to primarily represent a sociocentric leadership philosophy that focuses on the well-being of the employees and sees the manager primarily as a supporting force that guides the employees accordingly. Thus, the focus is not (only) on profit optimisation, but also on the well-being of the employees.

The comparison of transformational and leadership is also described as a relevant stream of research by Andersen (2018): “Although these theories share several characteristics, servant leaders focus on their followers’ well-being, while transformational leaders tend to focus more on organisational goals. (...) the community orientation of servant leadership differentiates it from transformational leadership” (p. 763)

In this way, the basic idea of servant leadership fits in with other seemingly current leadership and management concepts. For example, sustainable and socially responsible leadership (see Hargreaves & Fink, 2012) aims to use leadership

approaches to create positive living and working conditions for all involved. Such an approach is increasingly demanded by both employees and other modern companies' stakeholders, as Tang and Tang (2012) explain. In this regard, reference can also be made to the concept of sustainable human resource management, which De Souza Freitas, Jabbour and Santos (2011) see as one of the most recent approaches to dealing with employees. Here, too, the focus is on creating working conditions that not only avoid stress for employees, but also actively try to create a positive environment for them that enables them to grow and develop their personality, their possibilities and their abilities.

This comparison makes it clear that a variety of other leadership approaches need not be understood as a counterpoint to servant leadership but rather can support it and its underlying philosophy. Consensual leadership, for example, as described in the framework of the Leadership Judgement Indicator (Faraci, Lock & Wheeler, 2013), explains a leadership style that tends to create the broadest possible consensus between managers and employees and to make decisions in the best interests of all parties. Transformational leadership (Conchie, 2013) seeks to intrinsically motivate employees and increase their motivation and commitment in this gentle way. Sustainable leadership and management approaches are fundamentally concerned with the possibility of shaping leadership in such a way that it is perceived as beneficial for all parties involved (Davies, 2007). Thus, in summary, it can be shown that the idea of servant leadership has also found its way into other leadership approaches accordingly.

One of the challenges arising for contemporary leaders – for which the humbleness described within the framework of servant leadership seems highly relevant – is the COVID-19 crisis. This thesis and the empirical works presented throughout it were developed during the time of the crisis following the initial spread of the pandemic and the subsequent societal and economic changes and developments. However, as the objective and scope of the studies developed throughout this dissertation project did not rely on the idea of crisis management or leadership throughout

a crisis, the consequences on leadership have not been acknowledged throughout the publications.

The crisis triggered by the Covid 19 pandemic has been described as one of the most influential economic crises (So, Chu & Chan, 2020; Zhang, Hu & Ji, 2020). Economic cycles and ecosystems are showing themselves to have been hit hard by the crisis, which must be noted at both regional and international levels (Sansa, 2020). The impact affects financial markets (Ali, Alam & Rizvi, 2020) as well as the labour market, which is very strongly influenced by the crisis in individual sectors (Bartik, Bertrand, Lin, Rothstein & Unrath, 2020).

In addition to this financial impact, reference must also be made to the social consequences of the crisis. In this regard, authors such as Thunström, Newbold, Finnoff, Ashworth and Shogren (2020) mention in particular the social distancing and the associated changes in the company organisation as a relevant impact which must be discussed in particular in a business context. For a large number of companies, this has resulted in the constellation that classic types of collaboration and face-to-face communication have increasingly had to give way to digital models of collaboration (Kawashima, Nomura, Tanoue, Yoneoka, Eguchi, Shi & Myata, 2020). The term home office covers a range of measures that lead to employees preferring to work from home and thus not being present at their traditional office workplace (Di Domenico, Pullano, Pullano, Hens & Colizza, 2020). Corresponding models of collaboration, which are also summarised under the broader term telework, have already existed for more than 20 years, which authors such as Messenger & Gschwind (2016) explain. This summarises a series of work models that provide for a spatial separation of the workplace (i.e. the company) and the actual work performance (Salaff, 2002). Employees who use such working models are accordingly able (or, in the context of the present crisis, even encouraged) to carry out their professional activities from outside the office premises, and preferably at their home location (Belzungegio-Eraso & Erro-Garces, 2020). Although home office and telework are often used as synonyms in this context, it should be noted that they are two distinct

concepts: In this context, telework is considered a generic term that combines different aspects of digital cooperation in working life. However, home office actually refers exclusively to working from one's own home and thus represents the preferred approach to this topic in the context of this pandemic, as Baert, Lippens, Moens, Weytjens and Sterkens (2020) explain. The primary aim was to avoid direct physical contact between people and thus limit the spread of the virus. In addition to this medical approach, which implied that avoiding physical proximity is a fundamental advantage, it must also be pointed out that with regard to this new form of cooperation, there appear to be business implications and effects in terms of the management of employees. Authors such as Contreras, Baykal and Abid (2020) explain, for example, that the management of employees in the home office is fundamentally different from that which typically takes place in office premises. In particular, the role of leadership communication seems to change in this respect. Classical types of cooperation that take place in office premises are, for example, characterised by a high degree of informal communication, which in many cases is not present to the same extent in the teleworking context. This must be emphasised especially against the background of prescribed telework, as it is now occurring in the context of the Corona pandemic. Unlike in naturally evolved situations, in many cases, the necessary or desirable structures and processes did not emerge in this regard, which should enable problem-free cooperation between managers and employees on the one hand and between the employees themselves on the other (Dolce, Vayre, Molino & Ghislieri, 2020). Because the use of home offices suddenly became the new standard within a few weeks, many companies were not able to create the corresponding processes that would ensure the appropriate management and control of employees in a socially acceptable way. This is described by Sostero, Milasi, Hurley, Fernandez-Macias and Bisello (2020), for example, as a fundamental challenge that distinguishes the prescribed use of home office from the naturally grown one. However, in this context, it should be pointed out that other researchers (Tavares, Santos, Diogo & Ratten, 2020) also name that the amplified usage of home office or telework, as it has now been implied in the context of the Covid-19 crisis, can also lead

to new opportunities for organizations on the one hand and for employees on the other hand - the crisis is therefore not only described as a challenge or as the problem, but also as an opportunity to create new working structures and models that can be described as more sustainable and, optimally, more efficient.

These changes directly impact the idea of organizational commitment and of leadership alike, as findings from the World Economic Crisis of 2008 indicate. Crises, regardless of the circumstances that caused them, always lead to a negative emotional feedback on an individual, group or overall societal level. This negative feedback can manifest itself in a wide range of emotions such as anger, confusion, depression, frustration, etc. (Giorgi, Arcangeli, Mucci & Cupelli, 2015). These emotions, which occur as a result of traumatic external circumstances, affect both the psychological and physical state and lead to a deterioration in the various areas of an individual's life. (Mucci, Giorgi, Roncaioli, Perez & Arcangeli, 2016). The impact of crises on employment and human resources is mainly illustrated in the literature by the example of the 2008 global financial crisis (Markovits, Boer & van Dick, 2014; Tijdens, Van Klaveren, Bispinck, Dribbusch & Öz, 2011; Zavras, Tsiantou, Pavi, Mylona & Kyriopoulos, 2013). Massive staff cuts, falling wages and a sharp rise in unemployment, combined with general insecurity, have led to an increase in mental illness and in the use of mental health services. (Giorgi, Arcangeli, Mucci & Cupelli, 2015). At the same time, as Giorgi et al. (2015) mention, in post-crisis times, when organisational resources are scarce, companies often focus on their overall survival rather than on employee well-being.

As research shows, in post-crisis times, individuals who have lost their jobs tend to experience more stress and its negative effects than those who have remained employed, and organisational employees further tend to show lower productivity and motivation (Mehri, Iqbal, Hekmat & Ishaq, 2011; Tijdens, Van Klaveren, Bispinck, Dribbusch & Öz, 2011). The explanation for this phenomenon is twofold. On the one hand, motivation decreases due to reduced job-related opportunities, such as bonuses and career advancement; on the other hand, people are

affected by surrounding insecurity caused by massive downsizing, salary cuts, bankruptcies and corporate restructuring (Giorgi et al., 2015).

Tijdens, Van Klaveren, Bispinck, Dribbusch and Öz (2011) conducted an analysis of the measures taken by Dutch and German-speaking companies as a consequence of and reaction to the crisis described here. The authors came to the conclusion that the strategic orientation of these corporate responses to the crisis in 2008 was fundamentally similar and typically consisted of three stages. Within these strategies, active reference is made to working capital management approaches, which already becomes clear when looking at the first stage, according to the authors: companies mainly reduced current, work-related costs such as bonuses for employees or investments in growth projects within the first phase of crisis management. These non-essential expenses were cut in the first phase in order to maximize the available working capital. It was not until the second phase that a more aggressive approach was taken, where, for example, new hires were reduced, temporary employment contracts were terminated and paid overtime was minimized as much as possible. Also, in this crisis phase, employees were mostly asked to use their still available or existing leave days. Outsourced work and external partners were reintegrated into the company as far as possible in this phase in order to save costs with the help of the company's own available manpower. Finally, according to Tijdens, Van Klaveren, Bispinck, Dribbusch and Öz (2011), the third phase of the crisis response strategy led to the first dismissals of existing permanent staff, i.e. the company's own employees, most of whom still found stable working conditions in the first two phases of the crisis response. However, according to the authors, the companies described this as particularly difficult and serious, which can be attributed not only to the companies' social responsibility but also to business management considerations. Even in times of crisis, according to the authors based on their findings, the war for talent (as Chambers, Foulon, Handfield-Jones, Hankin and Michaels, 1998, called the active search for top employees) is a relevant issue for companies. Thus, if companies have to dismiss these employees, at least

temporarily, due to the crisis response measures, this can jeopardise the sustainable success of the company and make it vulnerable to external attacks.

These results from the World Economic Crisis indicate the potential developments the economy might face in the aftermath of the Covid-19 induced crisis. Simultaneously, it needs to be clarified that the challenges arising from the societal and economic changes in this aftermath might be distinctively different and more complex, as not only economic outcomes but also the approach towards work and collaboration itself changed. This seems especially evident in regard to the leadership challenges arising from what Waizenegger, McKenna, Cai and Bendz (2020) label as *enforced work-from-home*. Here authors such as Kirchner, Ipsen and Hansen (2021) predict that the changes induced by the pandemic and the subsequent crisis might be of sustainable nature and thus might significantly change the approaches to leadership. The basic assumption seems to be that the pandemic and its consequences will also have long-term effects on telework and home office use. For example, Dubey and Tripathi (2020) explain that the attitude of many people (and companies) has changed through the use of such models. For many companies, the enacted work-from-home strategy (see Waizenegger et al., 2020) was the first glimpse of this new way of working. According to this, this development was perceived quite positively by a large part of the people studied by Dubey and Tripathi (2020), so that the crisis could have served to reduce prejudices against telework and home office. The greatly intensified trend towards home office work also seems to offer new opportunities for both minorities and women, according to a recent study by Arntz, Yahmed and Berlingieri (2020). They explain that existing problems such as the gender gap in pay could perhaps be minimised in the future.

Therein lays one of the main outlooks and subsequently to be developed research questions. The present work showcased from various perspectives, how leaders and their (communication) behavior can affect employee-related outcomes. These results stem from a classical perspective, where leadership was conducted mostly on a face-to-face level of interaction. While the author of this study argues that approaches such as transformational leadership might remain their relevance

in different leadership scenarios, it still will require a new research approach to analyze how contemporary leaders can and should operate in what Yanow and Good (2020) describe as the *new normality*. However, it can be argued that the transformational approach described throughout this thesis (see section 2.1) rather can be seen as a mind-set or a strategy, than as a toolkit. Therefore, it seems plausible that transformational leadership's general ideas might retain their relevance, while the tools used to implement the strategic approach might develop.

6.3 Conclusion

Within the introduction of this thesis, the author argued that one of the main contributions of the present work lies in the assessment of organizational commitment from an employee-focused perspective, as therein not the intended consequences of leadership, but also the (partially) unintended consequences can be assessed. While – so the author argues – a focus on leaders themselves might lead to a fostered understanding, how they *try* and *aim* to lead, the perspective taken on in the present work rather focuses on how leaders *do* lead and how their employees perceive their leadership. However, while the benefits of this perspective are discussed throughout this thesis, the perspective, of course, will need future supplementation in subsequent research. Perceived leadership and the employee perspective are shown repeatedly over the course of this paper and throughout the papers published over the course of this thesis (Meixner 2020, 2020b, 2021) to be relevant predictors of employee-related outcomes such as organizational commitment, which in turn, is considered to be crucial for economic success of most companies (Ali, Rehman, Ali, Yousaf & Zia, 2010). However, it can be argued that perceived leadership is – of course – also the consequence of actual leadership actions, however: not only of these actual leadership actions. This leads back to the notion mentioned within section 1.3 in regard to the philosophical approach to leadership explained there by Suchanek and von Broock (2017): The contemporary VUCA business environment implies, that actions do not only have their intended consequences, but also a multitude of what Suchanek and von Broock (2017) call *side effects*. This also

becomes evident with regards to the present research and can be among the explanations, why *perfect* prediction models cannot exist in such a highly complex environment and why authors such as Sekaran and Bougie (2016) argue, that for business research only strong research designs that account for the possible presence of *side effects* can be feasible.

At the same time, it can be argued that the high relevance of transformational leadership as an approach seems so reasonable. Transformational leadership, authors such as Bass (1999) or Leithwood and Jantzi (2005) showcase, is more than a toolkit – it is a mindset and a vision. More *hands-on* approaches to leadership such as the four distinct leadership action strategies described within the situational leadership framework (Faraci, Lock & Wheeler, 2013) seem to be drastically different here: These strategies focus on clearly explained actions that leaders should undertake in certain situations, as they are characterized within the framework. Thus, the recommendations uttered towards leaders are much more concrete than those proposed by the framework of transformational leadership. Transformational leadership – unlike some other approaches such as individual recommendations proposed within the situational leadership framework - focuses on creating relationships between the company or the leader and the employees and shaping these relationships by a mindset of compassion and a strong belief in the common cause. This more abstract approach to leadership thus seems more applicable to the VUCA business environment (Lawrence, 2013). As circumstances are not always clear and possible outcomes of actions are partially unpredictable, Suchanek and von Broock (2017) argue that a moral and visionary framework to guide leaders might be more useful than a set of tools and rules.

This becomes evident as well with a gaze towards the leadership challenges described throughout section 2.1.2 and throughout the limitations presented in section 4.3 of the thesis. Especially the developments in the light of the Covid-19 crisis seem to clarify in a very concrete form how the business environment can shift within a very short time period, making a wide variety of recommendations and strategies for contemporary leaders obsolete (Stoller, 2020). New strategies and

toolkits are developed, such as the ones summarized by Bartsch, Weber, Büttgen and Huber (2020), as *digital leadership* or approaches combining the idea of crisis management and employee leadership (Forster, Patlas & Lexa, 2020). However, the relevance of an approach such as the transformational leadership still seems valid: As transformational leadership as proposed by Bass (1999) and Bass and Riggio (2006) does not focus on concrete tools or operational approaches, rather on a strategy and vision, it might still be applied to new forms of collaboration such as telework or work from home. Although the increased distance between leaders and employees in these models influences transformational leadership's practical implementation, the approach still seems valid, as Brunelle (2013) argues. Rather, transformational leadership might even gain in relevance in such scenarios, as Brunelle (2013) summarizes: "On the basis of our results, we conclude that supervisors, through their leadership style, are able to at least partially compensate for the injurious effects of distance. This finding is coherent with earlier studies indicating that immediate supervisors have a special place in the relationship between employees and their employers. The immediate superior therefore needs to focus on maintaining good relations with the subordinate." (Brunelle, 2013, p. 10) Thus, Brunelle (2013) shows that not only despite new types of work collaboration but even especially in the light of those, transformational leadership poses a strong contribution to fostering employee relationships and subsequently organizational commitment. This is in strong alignment with the present thesis, where along with two individual studies, the strong relevance of transformational leadership behavior for all aspects of organizational commitment was shown to be the strongest predictor (Meixner, 2020b; 2021) – independent of personality variables or personal values.

This is also a concluding link to the aforementioned literature on cultural fit and corporate culture: While Aycan, Kanungo and Sinha (1999) explain that the creation of a fit between personal values and organizational culture is crucial for fostering a beneficial commitment, the results shown by Meixner, Pospíšil and Zufan (2021) indicate, that personal values seem to play only a minor role in comparison to leadership aspects. However, it can be argued that it might be due to the culturally

inclusive approach transformational leadership implies that values only seem to be such a minor contributor.

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